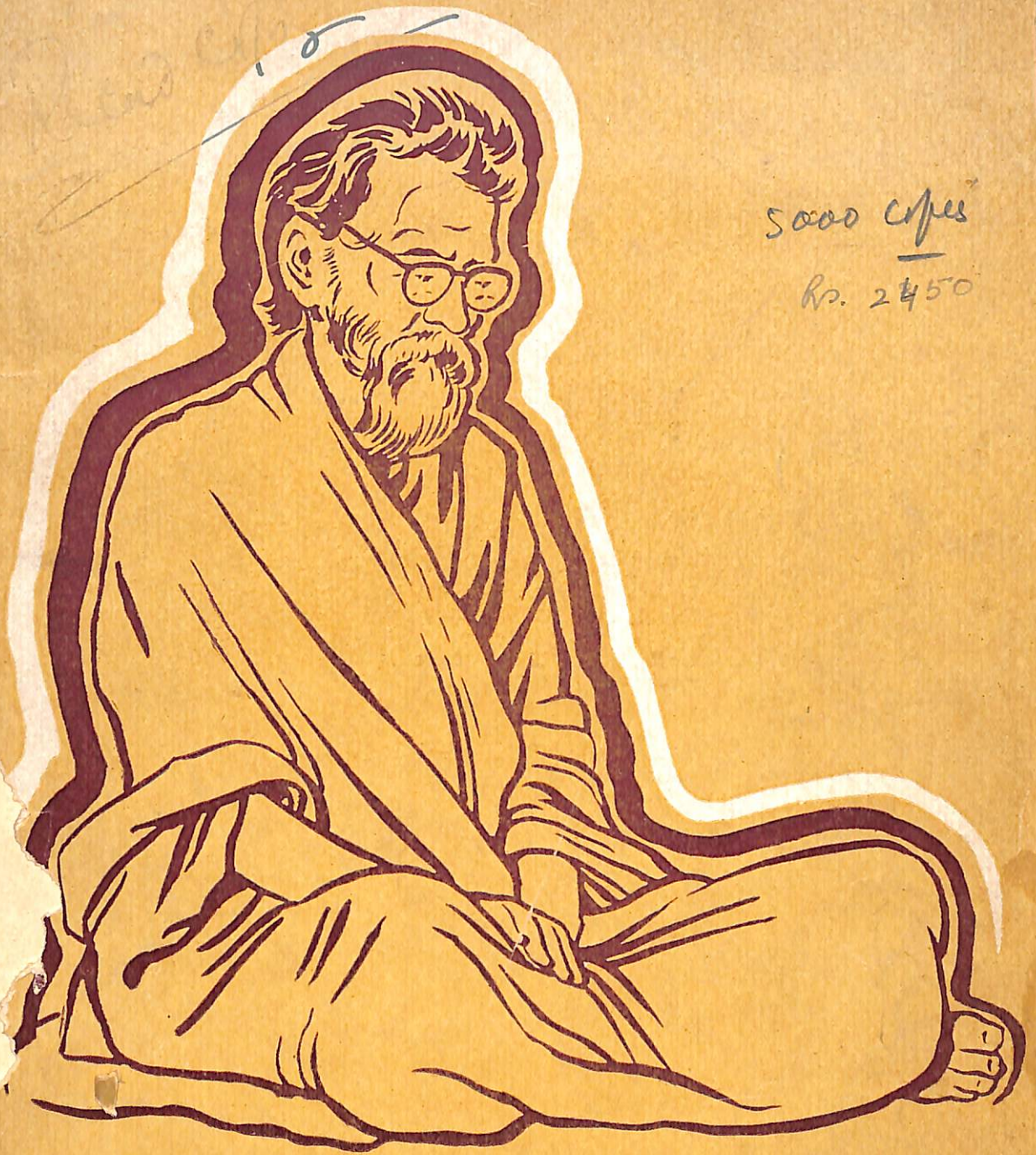




Acharya Vinoba Bhave

January 1955

Re. 1, 2s. 35 cents



Parag Chokkar

30/6/2001

ACHARYA VINOBA BHAVE



THE PUBLICATIONS DIVISION
Ministry of Information and Broadcasting
Government of India

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Vinoba Bhave at Khadigram in Bihar

CHAPTER I

INTRODUCTORY

In March 1951, a lone, frail *satyagrahi* set out on foot from Wardha for Hyderabad to see things for himself in the areas affected by communism in Telangana; nobody knew then that this would turn out to be a major event in the history of modern India.

Acharya Vinoba Bhave was on his March !

Vinoba's lone mission to Telangana reminds us of the hazards of a similar pilgrimage which Gandhiji undertook only six years earlier. In 1946, when we were on the threshold of freedom, violent communal



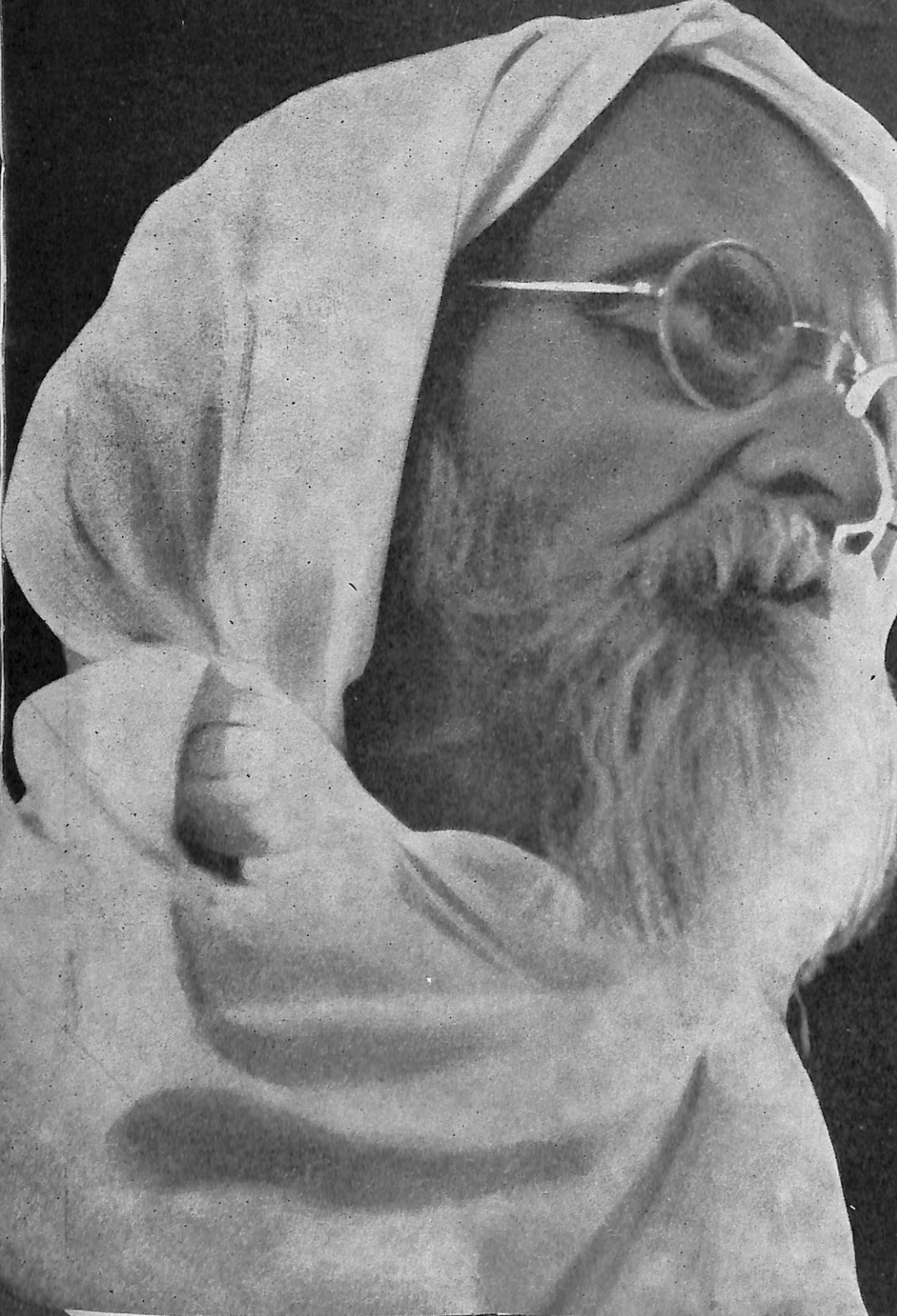
Addressing the All-India Sarvodaya Sammelan at Bodh Gaya

riots had broken out in a number of places in the country; in some parts of India, particularly Noakhali in Bengal and some parts of Bihar and the Punjab, chaotic conditions prevailed. Gandhiji went barefoot from village to village through a most difficult countryside in Noakhali, lived on local fruit and vegetables, and worked day and night to instil the message of courage in the hearts of the Hindus and love in the hearts of the Muslims. "I have only one object in view and it is a clear one, namely that God should purify the hearts of Hindus and Muslims and the two communities should be free from suspicion and fear of one another," declared Gandhiji.

Acharya Vinoba, like his Master, trekked through the terror-stricken areas of Telangana with the message of peace and goodwill. Both the Master and the disciple had a common purpose—to plant the message of peace, courage and love in the wilderness of hatred and terror.

But as Acharya Vinoba Bhave walked into the pathless maze of the countryside in Telangana, he saw 'light' and sprang on a bewildered people an idea which had in it all the elements of a new philosophy. "God", he said to himself first and to others later, "has created land and men cannot claim to be its owners. They can only be its servants. Instead of realizing this we want to be its masters. It is an unsustainable claim. Therefore, recognize the right of the landless to land". Therein lay the beginnings of what came to be known as the "*Bhoodan Yajna*"—ritual sacrifice in the form of voluntary land gift. This has brought about a considerable change in the perspective of the land problem in India and a new sense of awakening in the country. Acharya Vinoba, however, is quite conscious of the fact that this is not a final solution of India's immense land problem, but is only creating a proper moral atmosphere which would bring about a change in human values.

Gandhiji led India's millions to political independence through *Satyagraha*. Now his disciple, Acharya Vinoba Bhave, is leading them to the other equally important half of India's freedom—economic independence, through *Sarvodaya*. Striding across the sub-continent like a *fakir*, Vinoba asks for land and gets it—in hundreds of thousands of acres, and with the goodwill of all. With the world's attention focussed on him Vinoba, describing himself as a "soldier of the *Shanti-sena* (Peace Brigade)", has again, like his Master, forcefully and convincingly demonstrated the power of the spirit. Armed with the weapons of truth and non-violence, humility, kindness and honesty, Vinoba seems to be creating a new kind of history with his unique success in *Bhoodan Yajna*.



CHAPTER II

THE MISSION

As we turn the pages of India's chequered history, we find that she has often adopted completely original methods for the solution of intricate and difficult problems.

The maldistribution of land and other means of production has led to acute discontent in India as elsewhere. Vinoba thinks that the growing economic inequalities and the increased concentration of wealth in fewer hands cannot but be regarded as very reactionary and cramping developments in the socio-economic life of our country. No country where a yawning gulf separates the few from the many—the rich from the poor—can ever hope to prosper. India is a pre-dominant agricultural country. Seventy per cent of her people live on the land. A peaceful solution of her land problem is therefore not only desirable but essential. "Let us realise that God wants this blessed land to make a successful experiment in bringing about a social and economic revolution by peaceful means", says Acharya Vinoba Bhave.

A true devotee of *Satya* (Truth) and *Ahimsa* (Non-violence), Acharya Vinoba is on a pilgrimage unparalleled in the history of mankind, seeking to found social justice entirely on the basis of the spiritual regeneration of his people.

Having drunk deep at the fountain of India's philosophic wisdom, having traversed the wide range of our ancient literature and culture, Vinoba is trying to compass a drastic change in the psychological attitude of man towards his material possessions.

To Vinoba the ethical and social regeneration of the Indian people is the only hope for this country—and for the world. Vinoba's new faith, rich in ethical content, has brought new hope to the ignorant, poverty-stricken millions of India. His ambition is to make universal brotherhood a reality for the rich and poor alike.

The Acharya is convinced that social justice and economic equality must be attained peacefully, without hatred, without violence and without crushing the human soul. His *Bhoodan Yajna* is *satyagraha* towards this end. He feels that once consciousness is aroused in a society where some own land and others are landless, there can be no peace. "People should accept the principle that all land, like air and water, belongs to God", says Vinoba. "If all land is socially owned the present discontent would disappear and an era of love, goodwill and co-operation will take its place", he declares.

"Unless the existing social order which is based on inequality, strife and conflict is replaced by one founded on equality and mutual co-operation, there could be no salvation of mankind", he emphasises with deep conviction.

Explaining his mission Vinoba once said: "Now that political freedom has been attained, we have to work for the establishment of equality and brotherhood in our country. I have called that *sarvodaya* (welfare of all).

"It is for the establishment of this *sarvodaya* that I have been going from village to village.....I call this my Five Year Plan. If all of you take up this work for the next five years and during that time succeed in transferring five crore acres of land, then, a great non-violent revolution has taken place."

But, then, a sudden thought crossed his mind. Why not, he reflected, ask whether any one in the audience would like to part with a part of his land in favour of these poor families. With very little expectation he said: "Is there any one here who would like to give away a portion of his land to these poor people?" Strangely enough, a person sitting right in front of Vinoba, stood up and said, "I have been looking for an opportunity to give away one-half of my 200 acres of land all these years; the auspicious moment has come now. I offer my 100 acres to you for redistribution among the poor folks of my village. I beg of you not to refuse this humble gift." Vinoba and the whole audience were touched. "This is a godsend", exclaimed

Vinoba. Then he asked the 40 Harijan families how many acres of land they would require. After a few minutes' consultation among themselves, one of them stood up and replied with strange humility, "Sir, we will be satisfied with only 80 acres, at the rate of 2 acres for each family". This reply was again a pleasant surprise for Vinoba and the audience. "It was an unprecedented event," said Vinoba later, "that a man asked for land and received it so easily".

That evening Vinoba reflected deep into the night and the unmistakable call from the inner sanctuary of his heart came distinctly commanding him to dedicate himself to this new kind of *Yajna*. That in short is the genesis of the *Bhoodan Yajna*.

Bhoodan Yajna is essentially a revolutionary process aimed at changing the mental outlook which would make possible a peaceful transference of ownership of land to the landless. "My movement", says Vinoba, "is primarily a moral movement for the regeneration of man and the reorientation of social and economic values of life".

Spinning at Rajghat during a visit to Delhi



Vinoba is preaching no new doctrine, however. It may be traced to the Upanishads. It only seems new because the times have given it a new urgency. Walking from one village to another in the country, he asks all those who have land to share it with those who have none. He tells his audience that "it is more blessed to give than to receive".

Many in India have doubted the efficacy of the *Bhoodan Yajna* in solving India's gigantic land problem. "There is no other way more effective than this", answers Vinoba. "My method is the simplest method. I ask for land, I get it and I give it. It fosters love and goodwill between the giver and the recipient. They feel the kinship of spirit".

Every party in India, irrespective of its political affiliations, including the Congress Party and the Socialists, approves Vinoba's movement. Even those who have no faith in non-violence do not denounce the man or his mission. They only express doubts about his method which they consider unworkable.

Although the *Bhoodan Yajna* by itself cannot be a conclusive answer to India's immense agricultural problem, it has none-the-less awakened a new consciousness and roused new hope in the heart of millions.

"My aim," Vinoba once declared, "is to bring about a three-fold revolution. Firstly, I want a change in people's hearts; secondly, I want to create a change in their lives; and thirdly, I want to change the social structure."

"My mission is not to stave off a revolution. I want to prevent a violent revolution and bring about instead a non-violent revolution. The future peace and prosperity of the country depends upon the peaceful solution of the land problem," he says.

The basic philosophy of the *Bhoodan* movement is that all children of the soil have an equal right to Mother Earth. It is therefore essential that the entire land of the country should be redistributed anew on a more equitable basis, providing roughly at least five acres of dry land or one acre of wet land to each family.

A psychological change like this cannot be brought about by violence. Vinoba is convinced that nothing can be achieved through pressure or force. "If force is to be used, then I am not required. My physical feebleness would be out of place there", says he.



Studying a report

According to him, class-hatred and class-conflict are not ordained by Providence. Social justice and the development of human personality are not contradictory and incompatible. "Love is more powerful than hatred. Harmony is more natural. Spirit can move mountains". Time has proved that *Satya* and *Ahimsa* are far more powerful than other weapons for the solution of human problems. It is the means that determine the ends and not vice versa. Bad means cannot be expected to produce good ends.

"If democracy were to survive in India and if a socio-economic revolution were to be achieved through peaceful and non-violent means", Vinoba says, "we must create an atmosphere of genuine love, self-sacrifice, corporate and co-operative action and moral purity".

The origin of Acharya Vinoba's *Bhoodan Yajna* is interesting and significant. In April 1951, Vinoba went to Shivarampalli (Hyderabad State) on foot to guide the deliberations of the Second Sarvodaya Samaj Conference. The Samaj is the spearhead of an all-India movement of all those who believe in the fundamental principles of Gandhian philosophy. After the Conference was over, Vinoba decided to return to Sevagram on foot through the Telangana area which had been the centre of intensive communist activities for some years. In Telangana the communists had started a movement for the redistribution of land among the landless peasants by destroying title deeds, threatening the landlords and terrorising the people through violence. When Vinoba announced his decision to walk through Telangana with a few co-workers, the Hyderabad State Government offered him police protection which he declined.

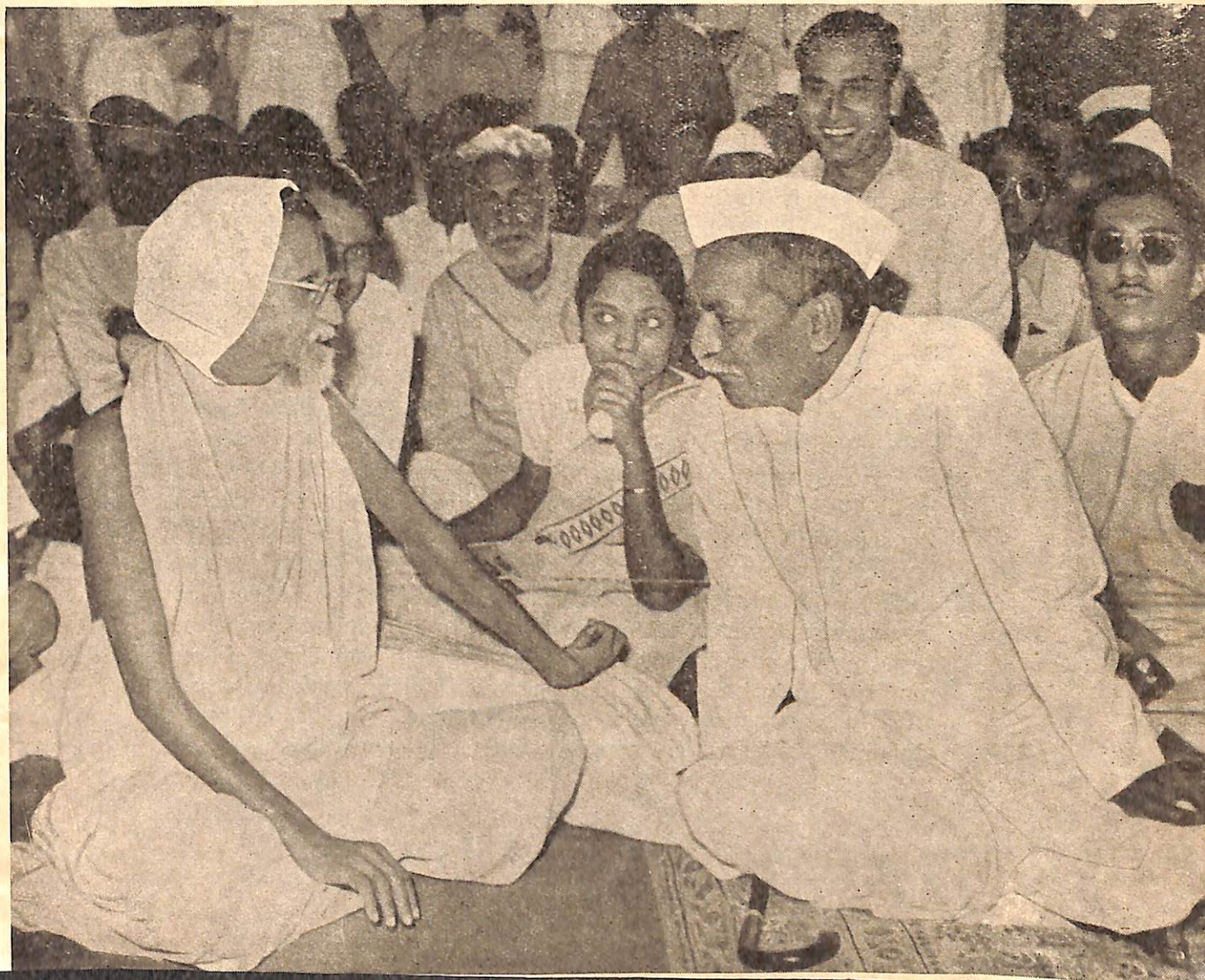
On the 18th day of April, 1951, the third day of his trek, Vinoba reached a village called Pochampalli. As he entered the village, 40 Harijan families surrounded him and begged him for land. Vinoba did not know what to do. He had no land of his own. So he said, "I will try to discuss the matter with the Government".

To those who have an excess of land, Vinoba appeals thus: "I have come to loot you with love. . . . If you have five sons, consider me as the sixth and accordingly give me my share for *Daridra Narayana*". And he reassures the impoverished landless labourers and tenants by saying: "We are all members of a single human family". Vinoba's entire approach to man's better nature has yielded

and is yielding astonishing results. He is extremely kind and considerate even to those who oppose him, his principles and his methods. "Although the communists commit acts of violence, still how can we hate them? I wish everyone to realize God. I pray to Him that He should kindle good faith in the heart of every man", he says. While addressing communists directly, he once asked: "Do you really believe in your ideology? If so, why not come in the day time instead of by night? If you want to loot the people, loot, as I do, with love and affection".

It should, however, be remembered that *Bhoodan* is a voluntary giving (*dan*) and sharing of the land. It is giving to others out of

With the President, Dr Rajendra Prasad



the consciousness that one has something which one can and ought to share with others.

Some have argued that this form of sharing of the land leads to a further fragmentation of land in India; they fear that it will affect our agricultural production adversely. But Vinoba always says, "There is more to fear from the fragmentation of human hearts than from the fragmentation of land." "Fragmented land", Vinoba says, "can be easily consolidated later with mutual goodwill and co-operation; but the fragmentation of hearts due to economic inequalities is full of dangerous possibilities".

He wants to counteract all bitterness with the positive action of love and sacrifice.

Moreover, Vinoba believes that the pattern of agriculture in a thickly populated sub-continent like India must be small-scale farming. Instead of trying to pool land, efforts should be made to introduce co-operative endeavour in the main agricultural operations like ploughing, weeding, harvesting. In other words, we should encourage "co-operative better farming", rather than "collective joint farming".

In order to relieve unemployment among the landless labourers and to satisfy their legitimate hunger for land, it is imperative to undertake a redistribution of land on a wide scale. Vinoba's *Bhoodan Yajna* is creating the necessary atmosphere for the transfer of land from the rich to the poor almost without any compensation but at the same time with goodwill. The potentialities of the *Bhoodan Yajna* are immense. Vinoba's movement will go down in the annals of history as one of the most potent landmarks in the titanic struggle of good against evil, of non-violence against violence, and of the forces of peaceful construction against the frenzy of hatred and destruction.

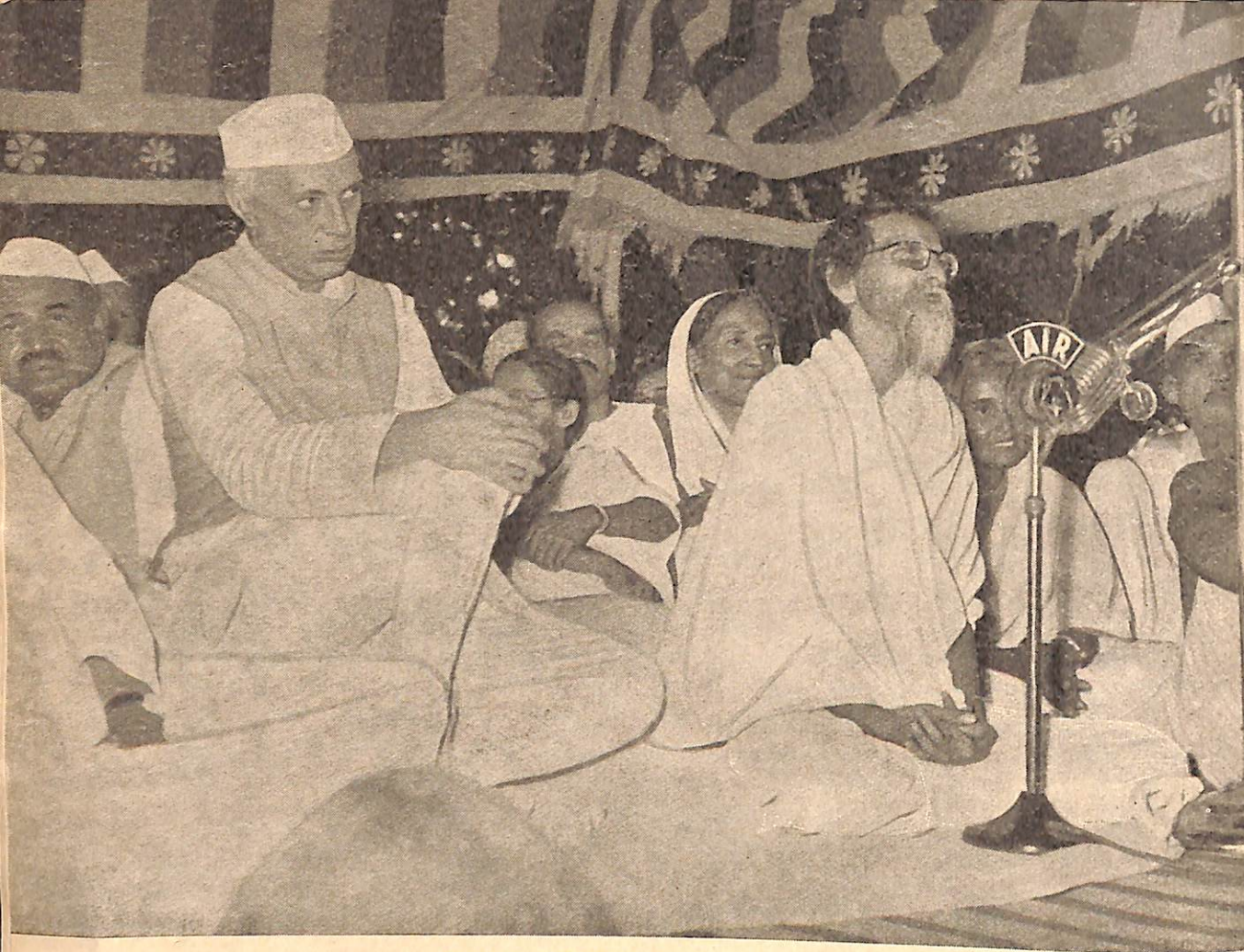
Can we say that Acharya Bhave is changing established values by his *Bhoodan* movement? Those who have witnessed his work and the spirit in which he is carrying it on can have no doubt about the revolutionary character of his movement. Everywhere he propagates the idea that property in land is wrong and that land should be as free as air and water. But, as water has to be regulated properly for social purposes, so must land be utilised for the welfare of the community. In insisting that all property should be treated as a sacred trust to be used for social ends, Acharya Vinoba is restating the Gandhian values which were in danger of disappearing.



At Gandhinagar in Jaipur

He has demonstrated the amount of social good that can be attained through personal example, character and the like—political power notwithstanding. The way he is seeking to solve the land problem shows that other problems can likewise be peacefully tackled by moral persuasion. He is creating such strong public opinion against landlordism as will make political and legal action on the part of the Government easy. Acharya Vinoba is creating in rural areas an army of workers, whose united action would work a new kind of social revolution in the countryside.

A silent revolution is thus taking place in the villages. It requires no great imagination to see its future possibilities. But it is often asked, can this *Bhoodan Yajna* wholly solve the land problem?



A session of the Sarvodaya Sammelan at Bodh Gaya

Obviously, no revolution can, at one stroke, solve the problems which caused it. A revolution, to begin with, removes psychological and moral hindrances to the working out of new solutions. After the removal of these hindrances begins the work of establishing new values through appropriate legal, political, economic and social institutions. Acharya Bhavé's *Bhoodan Yajna* must be viewed in this light.

Can we say that by advocating social ownership of landed agricultural property, Vinoba is working against the spirit of our Constitution? When asked about it, the Acharya unequivocally remarked, "My attempt is to create an atmosphere in which the limitations of the Constitution, if any, can be got rid of".

Vinoba is not against all legislation. "My plan also envisages legislation at the end", he once said, "but I want to begin with pity and kindness". What he is particular about is that "legislation should not be forced on the people. Every one including the landowner should, when it comes, accept it". Vinoba does not think that non-violence and legislation are incompatible and opposed to each other. "Non-violence does not rule out legislation but it should be a legislation backed by public opinion", he said at a public meeting. And the backing of public opinion is ensured only when a suitable atmosphere is created. "If the landlords are convinced of the rights of the landless to the land," Acharya Vinoba once observed, "the proper atmosphere for suitable legislation will have been created."

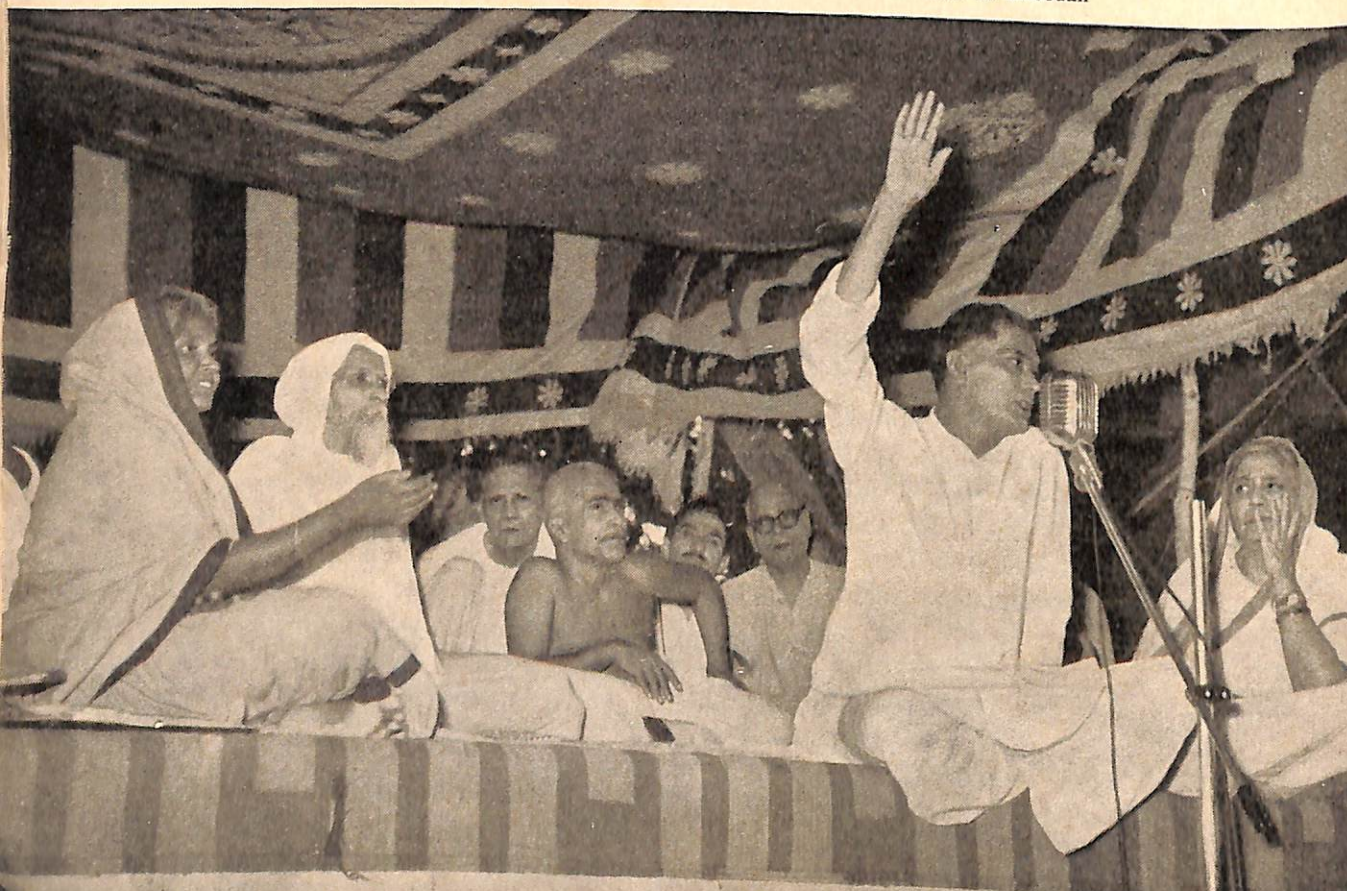
Many in India and abroad suspect Vinoba of being a communist. Asked whether he felt the need of *samyavada* (communism), Vinoba said, "I do not believe in *samyavada*. I believe in *samyayoga* (the practice of equality) and feel its need." *Samyayoga* is, Vinoba thinks, the only effective alternative to the cult of *samyavada*, which has, of late, made its appearance in our land. *Samyayoga* aims at the attainment of the welfare of all and depends on a change of heart through moral appeal and persuasion, and not on force and violence. *Bhoodan Yajna* is an effective instrument of peaceful revolution in the agrarian field, seeking to secure land for the landless through love and non-violence. It manifests the efficacy of *samyayoga* as a corrective for the present inequalities and inequity prevalent in the world of human relations. "The practice of equality", Vinoba says, "or even an initiation into it is better than shouting slogans and shedding blood for equality."

It will be a desirable thing for the fanatical adherents to the alien cult of violence, class-hatred and class-conflict to realize the significance of Vinoba's epoch-making experiment and offer him full co-operation as other parties of the country have been doing. Rightly did Vinoba observe in a prayer meeting at Schigarh, "When people tell me about heaven in Russia, I only want to tell them that it is only too early to say anything about all that has happened there. Let me also add that if violence has rendered such immense service to the people there, non-violence can surely render greater and much greater service to humanity."

Critics of Vinoba's *Bhoodan* movement often argue that the land given as a gift is often of poor quality, barren, rocky and uncultivable. Vinoba says, "To my mind no land can be called useless. I will make full use of even the poorest quality land, even the rocky tracts and hills." More than the quality land, Vinoba emphasises, is the fact of people's willingness to part with their property voluntarily for a social cause; Vinoba sees in this the seeds of a mighty revolution. Apart from the moral and psychological value of the movement, the poor quality land could be utilised for pastures, afforestation, the rehabilitation of D.Ps., and so on. "It is interesting to note," Vinoba observes, "that most of the poor quality land has been donated not by the poor but by the rich. It is a curious phenomenon that God has made the hearts of the poor rich and those of the rich poor."

Dr. S. Radhakrishnan, Vice-President of India, described the *Bhoodan Yajna* as a movement which is preparing the "public mind for a drastic social and economic revolution—a revolution which will be brought about by consent and not by coercion."

Jayaprakash Narayan appeals for dedication to the cause of Bhoodan



Shri Jayaprakash Narayan, Socialist leader, who has dedicated his entire life to the cause of the *Bhoodan Yajna*, thinks that Vinoba's movement is a "bold experiment in a non-violent socio-economic revolution."

Acharya Bhave has, during the past three years, trekked over 10,000 miles and has collected from 3,45,321 donors, 34,66,462 acres of land for free distribution among the landless population.

Having done so much, Vinoba claims with genuine humility that he is not saying or doing anything new. He is merely "an humble seeker who is trying to walk in the footsteps of his Master." But like all great followers, he is interpreting the Master's message in a dynamic manner, enriching and developing it, giving it new strength and "saving it from becoming a set of dead formulae and 'patrified rituals'".

Distribution of Land Gifts

It is not only Vinoba's method of land collection that is unique; his method of redistributing the land among the landless is even more revolutionary. The Harijans, the most down-trodden section of the landless population, will be given one-third of the land to be distributed. But whether they are Harijans or other sections of the landless population, all of them have to satisfy the following four conditions :

- (a) landlessness,
- (b) poverty,
- (c) capacity to till the land, and
- (d) a desire to own land and look after it.

In the redistribution of land priority is given to those who fulfil these conditions best. The distribution takes place at public meetings in a village. All the tests are applied publicly. One of Vinoba's followers is also present. The unanimity of the decisions is ensured by the open nature of the public meetings where the distribution is made. In case of a 'tie', a toss should decide the issue, as a "toss is believed to be the verdict of God." Of course, the technique of love and fellow-feeling applied to the securing of land for the landless would form the basis of an equitable redistribution of land so collected. The co-operation of village *panchayats*, which exist in most Indian villages, is to be sought not only for the task of land distribution but to enable the recipients and beneficiaries to make a start on the land allotted to them.

So far the distribution of the land collected by him has not yet begun in all the States. While in Hyderabad and Uttar Pradesh it has been taken up partially, in Bihar it has just started and figures to be given have been distributed.

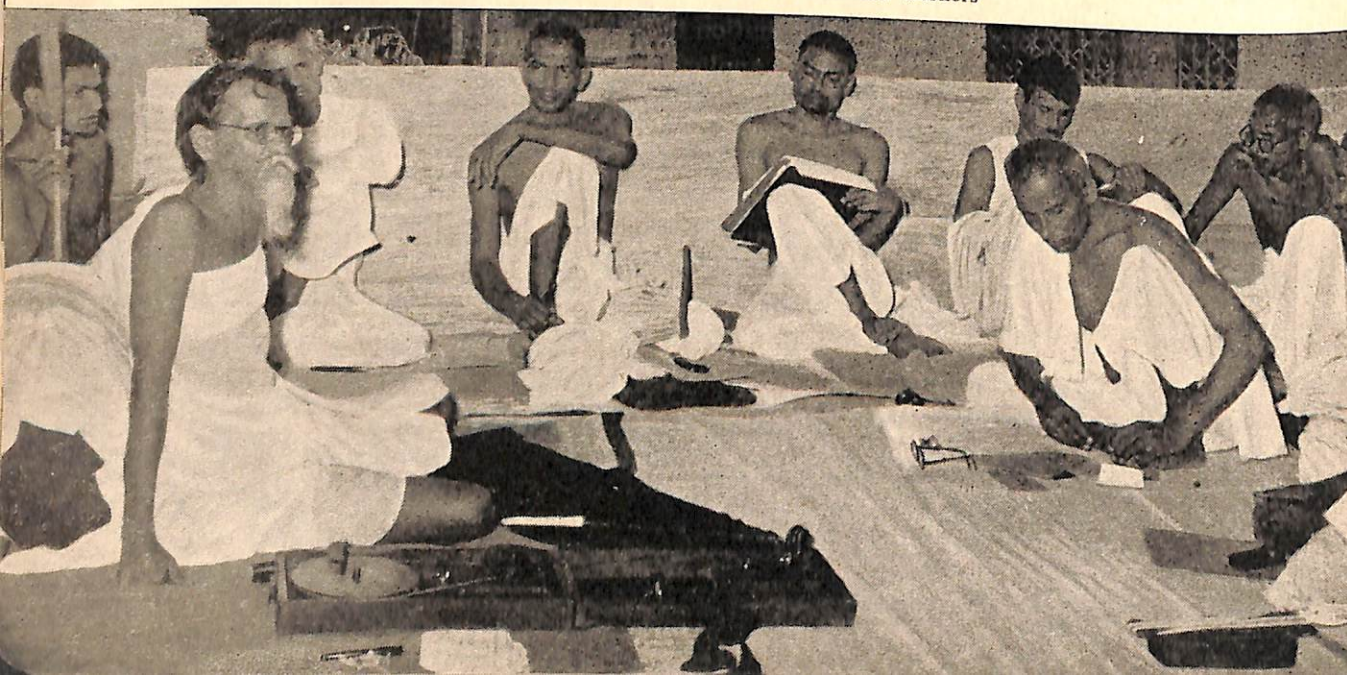
Moving scenes were witnessed when land was distributed for the first time in U.P. Twelve families took the dust from the feet of Vinoba whose mission had opened the gates of a new life for them.

It was found that in the Pukharyan village in U.P., there were seven landless families but the land available for distribution was sufficient only for two families. Acharya Vinoba made a fervent appeal to all those present. The audience was deeply touched and the land owners voluntarily offered donations of more and more land so that the demands of all the landless families were met. It is significant to note that among the donors who responded to Acharya Vinoba's appeal were a Socialist worker and a *Patwari*.

Speaking on the occasion, Vinoba observed: "People, even my sympathisers, had few hopes about the success of my mission. I find not the slightest doubt in my mind that I had a clear vision before me. It is because the Gita, my mother taught me to do my duties in a spirit of non-attachment without which I should have retreated at the first set-back and run after the legislatures to achieve my end".

"Fortunately like a free man", said Acharya Bhawe, "I was unconcerned regarding the results of my efforts".

An informal meeting with Bhoodan workers



CHAPTER III

MAN BEHIND THE MOVEMENT

Who is the man behind the movement? What kind of philosophy is this that speaks of enriching the poor without impoverishing the rich? Was he born under noble stars? No. Vinayak Narahari Bhave, known to millions in India as Vinoba, makes no such claim.

Vinoba was one of the most trusted and faithful disciples of Mahatma Gandhi. His simple dress, his emaciated body, his bifocal glasses, his calm soft voice with kindly humour, bring back to us memories of the departed Mahatma. Even though he is one of the most learned of men in India today, it is not merely his learning that has won him the affection of his countrymen. Vinoba, like their beloved Bapu, has brought new hope and promise of a new life and prosperity to them.

It was the land of seers and sages like Nivriti, Gyandev, Ramdas, Eknath and Tukaram, of warriors and politicians like Shivaji and Bal Gangadhar Tilak, that gave birth to Vinoba. Born on September 11, 1895, Vinayak Narahari Bhave is the eldest of five children—four sons and one daughter—born to Narahari and Rukmini Bhave. The Bhaves of Gagoda, Tehsil Pen, District Kolaba, in Maharashtra, were fairly well-to-do Brahmins. Vinoba's father, Narahari Bhave, had a diploma in dyeing from the Maharaja Gaikwad's *Kala Bhavan* and belonged to the first batch of students of the institute. He served for sometime in the Dyeing Department of Buckingham Mills. British Khaki was a contribution of the *Kala Bhavan*. In order to give a proper education to his children, Narahari Bhave resigned his post with the Buckingham Mills and went to Baroda. He was employed



in the State Government service as a typist clerk. Narahari was a man of modern outlook and his bias was for industrial education.

The youngest of the brothers died very young. Balkrishna Bhawe, the second brother, was in charge of the Nature Cure Centre in Uruli Kanchan which was started by Gandhiji. Now he is in charge of a nature cure centre in South Africa. The third brother, Shivaji Bhawe, a great Sanskrit scholar and a student of history, formerly lived in Dhulia, but is now looking after Vinoba's *Paramdham Ashram* at Paunar.

Most beloved of his mother Rukmini, Vinoba was inspired by the devotional songs she sang in his childhood. With songs in her heart and the name of God on her lips, she dedicated whatever she did to the Almighty. It is said that she never ate anything until she had shared it with her neighbours—the duty of distribution being enjoined upon her beloved Vinya (for that was Vinoba's pet name).

Entering school in 1907, Vinoba never wasted his time. Up to the sixth standard, he was always at the top of his class. He then lost interest in school studies but somehow passed his examinations. His store of knowledge, however, went on increasing. He was selective in all his studies; things enduring appealed to him rather than things transient. Mathematics and philosophy have been his favourite subjects. Of mathematics, he wrote: "Next to God if I love anything best, it is mathematics. My passion for mathematics was so great that I would be absorbed in solving problems while my food waited for hours. I was exceptionally strong in mathematics. Some problems and riders that had tried the capacity of my teachers, I solved easily." And mathematical precision marks all his thought and action.

"When I was nine", Vinoba was to tell his disciples later, "I developed a passion for *Kesari*, the famous Marathi weekly of Tilak. I studied articles in it on every conceivable topic and it laid the foundation of practically all my learning. I got hold of *Dasabodha* which I read over and over again. Tukaram, Moropant, Eknath and Jnaneshwar were the great souls I was early familiar with and I have read and re-read their writings and made them my own".

He formed a little group of boys, called the *Vidyarthi Mandal*, where all that they read was discussed and debated. All these studies and discussions were working a silent revolution in Vinoba.

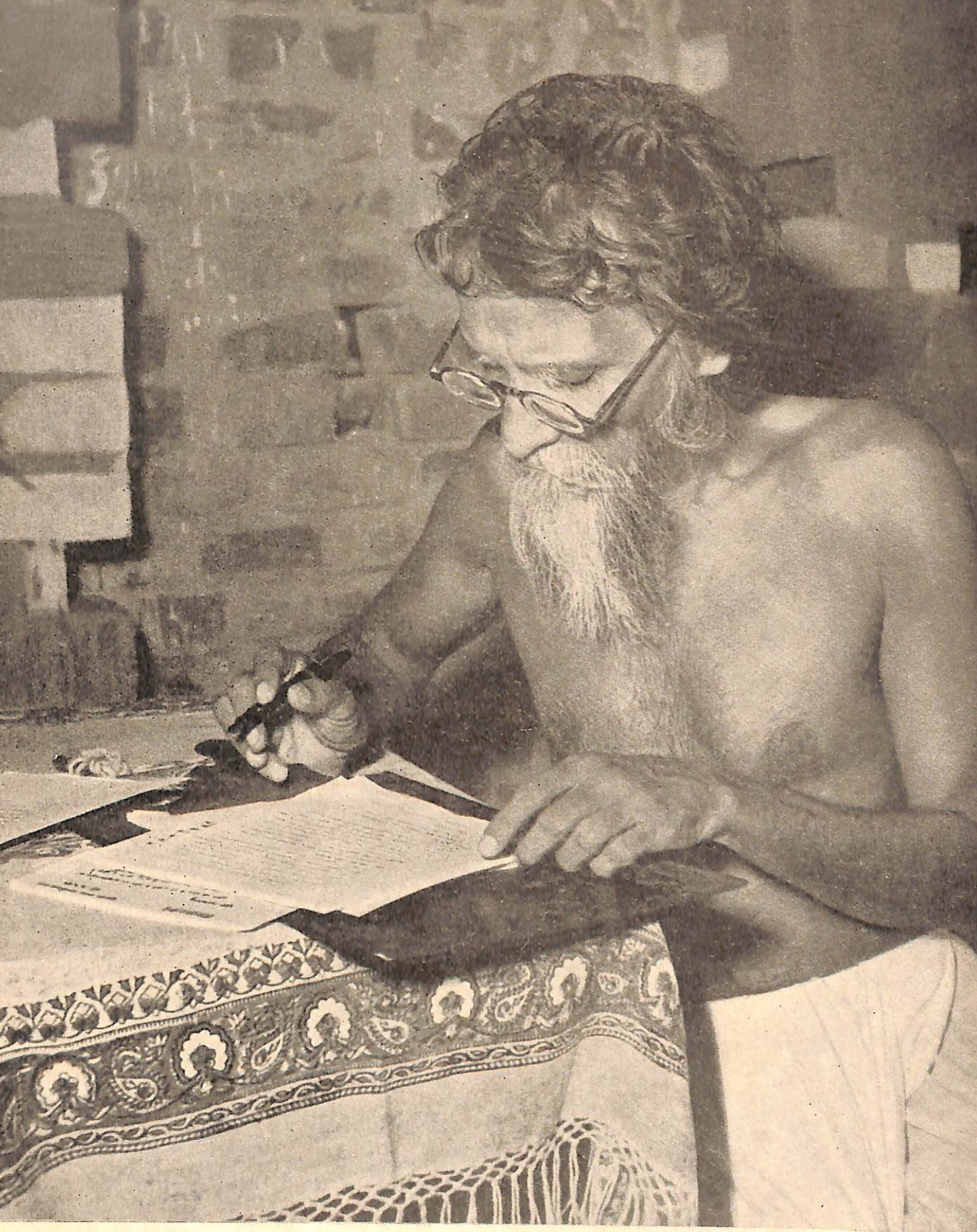
"Dasabodha and Kesari left so deep an impression upon me", Vinoba once revealed, "that I dedicated myself to the country. I thought if I married I would not be able to serve the country. The secret of *brahmacharya* I came to know at a later stage. I had determined to read nothing without digesting it and putting it into practice. Once I read that a *brahmachari* should abjure soft beds and pillows and hot water for baths. I threw aside my bed and began bathing in cold water. I cannot tell you how difficult it was to persuade my mother to allow me this. She was shocked. She would not give me cold water. I was also adamant. For fifteen days I went without a bath until at last the loving mother thought it fit to bend to the wishes of the wicked imp".

Vinoba is a *brahmachari*; he had taken the vow of *brahmacharya* even before he joined Gandhiji's Sabarmati Ashram. *Brahmacharya*, to him, is not a stratagem to escape the economic stress of marriage, or a sophist's formula to be rid of domestic burdens. To Vinoba, it is an ideal, rather the foundation of all other ideals. It is a special path in a seeker's journey towards the Ultimate.

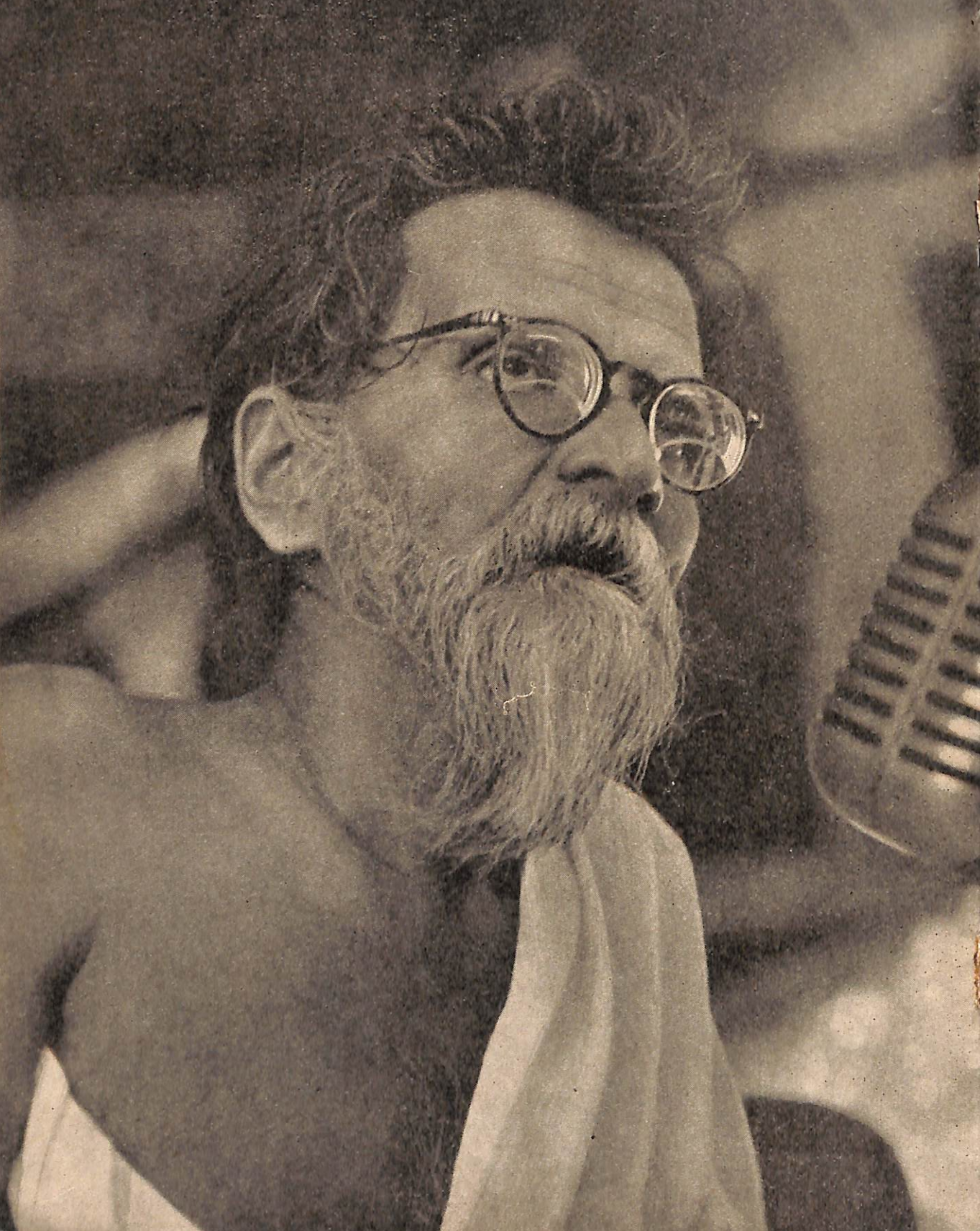
But *brahmacharya* has not lessened Vinoba's interest in life and zeal for living. According to Vinoba *brahmacharya* does not mean quenching the inner fire and reducing it to ashes, but making it burn incessantly, eternally and more radiantly than ever. To burn out the senses and to become a cripple who forfeits the joy of life is not self-restraint.

"My refusal to do things succeeded well with mother but", Vinoba said, "not so with father who used to belabour me heavily. Once there were guests in the house. Father asked me to get cigarettes for them. Cigarettes? I would not get them. I went away. Many of my fads such as going barefoot, abjuring of beds, devoting more attention to Marathi than to English, earned me his serious displeasure and active wrath. But I remained as self-willed as I was".

"My father", he once told his students, "was very anxious to see me become a barrister or a big chemist for which he wanted me to go to Germany. And, indeed, I gave early promise of such things. I was easily at the top in the class. I used to read general Marathi books the whole day but it took me little time to get ready for the class. My father thought that he should exploit all this intelligence. He forgot his duty as a *brahmin* and thought, like a *vaishya*, in terms

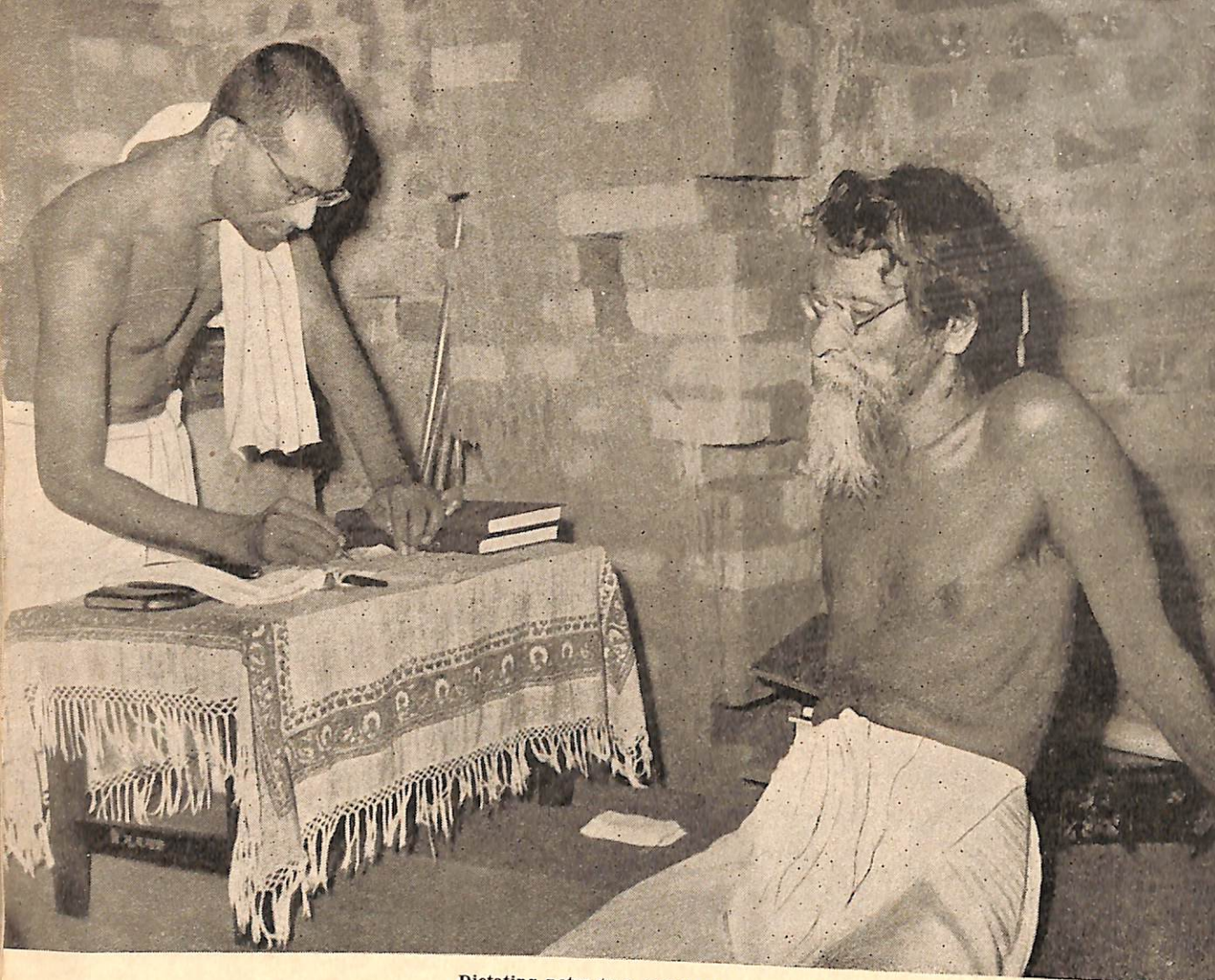


At work





Speaking at the
Sarvodaya Sam-
melan



Dictating notes to a secretary

of pounds, shillings and pence. This incensed me. I determined that I would be no party to my intelligence being prostituted".

Vinoba has been very studious from his early childhood. To quote him, "I forgot everything when engrossed in my studies and my discussions. On the occasion of my sister's wedding I was buried in my studies. Someone asked me the name of my brother-in-law. I blushed. I did not know his name even".

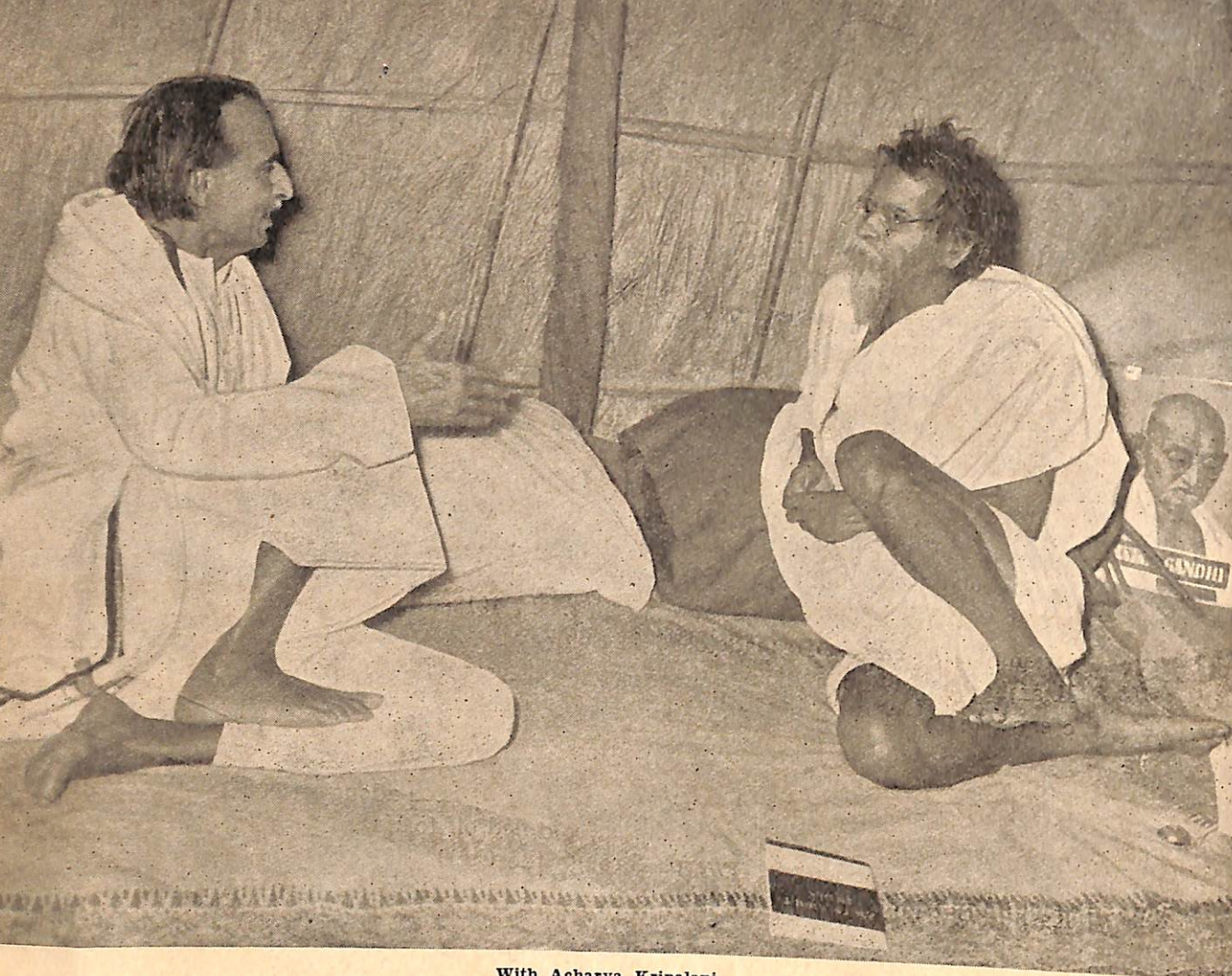
A day soon came for the boy to leave his home. Vinoba was sick of his surroundings. He was anxious to be free of them. "I also saw the slavery of this education. I left my early friends. I felt that they were wasting their days after a false education. I wanted to learn Sanskrit, but I was set to learn French because my father intended me to go abroad for education. I decided that I must flee from all these," he said reminiscently.

He was living in Baroda at that time. In 1913, the University Examinations came. He had to go to Bombay for his Intermediate Examination. Vinoba thought this the best opportunity for him to escape from his surroundings. So, instead of going to Bombay, he broke journey at Surat and fled to Banaras by the Taptee Valley Railway. Referring to this incident, he later told his disciples, "I took two or three of my classmates into the conspiracy, indited a long letter to my father, posted it at Baroda station, and fled off to Kashi.

"Father learnt long afterwards through the C.I.D. that I was in Kashi. But he (father) was no less self-willed than I. He left me severely alone", Vinoba wrote.

Vinoba begin to study Sanskrit in Banaras. Within the three years that he spent there, he became an accomplished *pundit*. In Banaras, he boarded in a *Dharmashala*, bathed in the Ganges and lived like a pauper. So great was the hardship of that life that one of his companions died of privation. It was at this juncture that he learned that Gandhiji had founded an *Ashram* in Sabarmati.

In 1916 Vinoba saw Gandhiji for the first time. Being too shy to see him personally, he wrote to him and Gandhiji invited him to go and join the Sabarmati *Ashram*. Later when the Mahatma learnt that his new disciple had not written to his parents for some years, he sat down himself and wrote to Vinoba's father. "Your Vinoba is with me. His spiritual attainments are such as I myself could achieve only after a long struggle".



With Acharya Kripalani

From his early childhood Vinoba was very deeply attached to his mother. Vinoba owed much to her. He often refers to her fondly in his writings. He writes:

“Like so many I also once said to mother: Here is a beggar strong and plump come to beg. To give alms to such a one is to encourage indolence and lassitude. And I cited in support the *Deshe Kale Cha Patre Cha* quotation from the Gita. Mother said, “The beggar that is come is God Himself. Now distinguish the deserving from the undeserving. Would you rate God as undeserving? Who are you and who am I

to distinguish one from the other? I do not see there is much to consider....." And Vinoba observes, "I have not to this day found a fitting reply to what mother said".

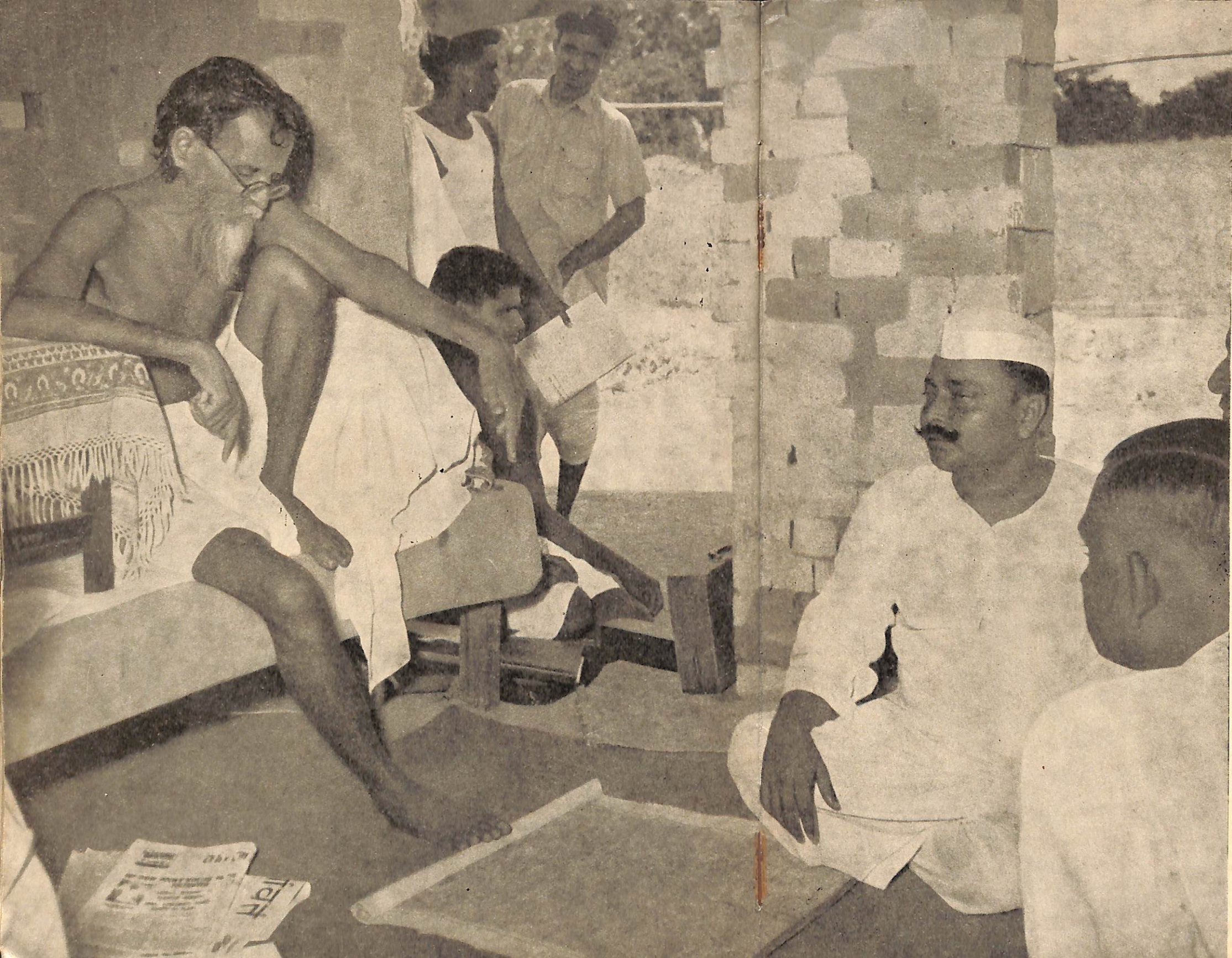
But within two years after he had joined the *Ashram* there came a shock. Vinoba's mother died in the great influenza epidemic of 1918.

Vinoba devoted the first few months in the *Ashram* to self-discipline. He gave eight hours a day to cooking and scavenging, never fearing that his scholarship would suffer thus. Then he started to expound the Gita and the whole *Ashram* was at his feet.

With all this Vinoba was restive. He began to feel that his

His room at Khadigram





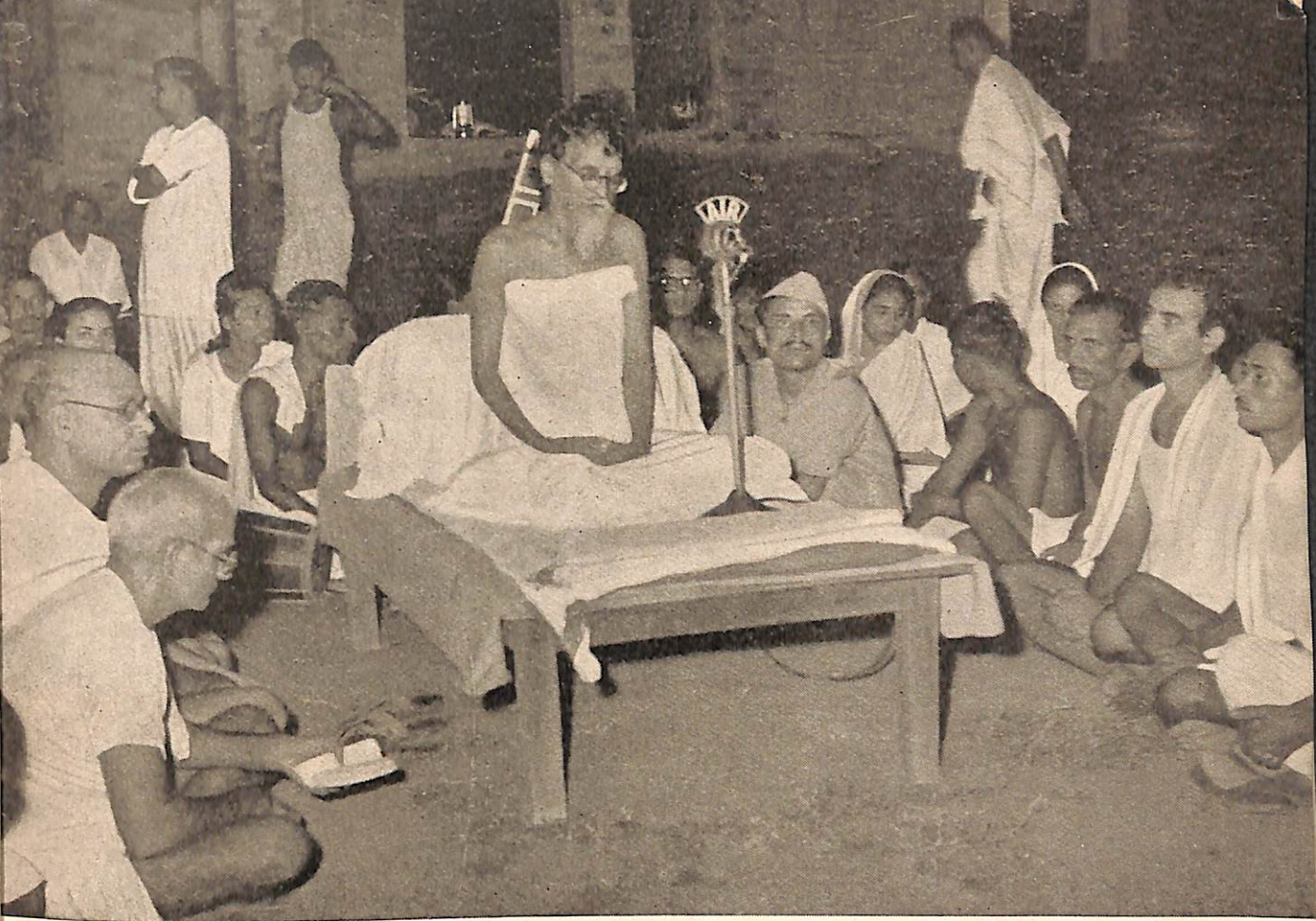
Discussing
Bhoodan with
Bihar landlords

intellectual equipment was inadequate. He wanted to continue his Sanskrit studies more. In pursuit of knowledge he took one year's leave and went to Wai, a health resort in Satara District, and thence again to Banaras. Wai, a sacred place situated at the foot of the Mahabaleshwar Hills, is a beauty spot on the banks of the Krishna river. There the Bhaves of Gagoda have a temple dedicated to Shiva. Vinoba took lessons from Narayana Shastri Marathe, a great Sanskrit scholar who had at that time his *Prajna Pathashala* in Wai.

Writing about Vinoba, the late Mahadev Desai, Gandhiji's Private Secretary, wrote: "In 1917 when Mr. Andrews was at the *Ashram*, I remember Gandhiji introducing Vinoba in these terms: 'He is one of the pearls in the *Ashram*. They do not come like others to be blessed by the *Ashram* but to bless it!'"

Prayers at the Sammelan

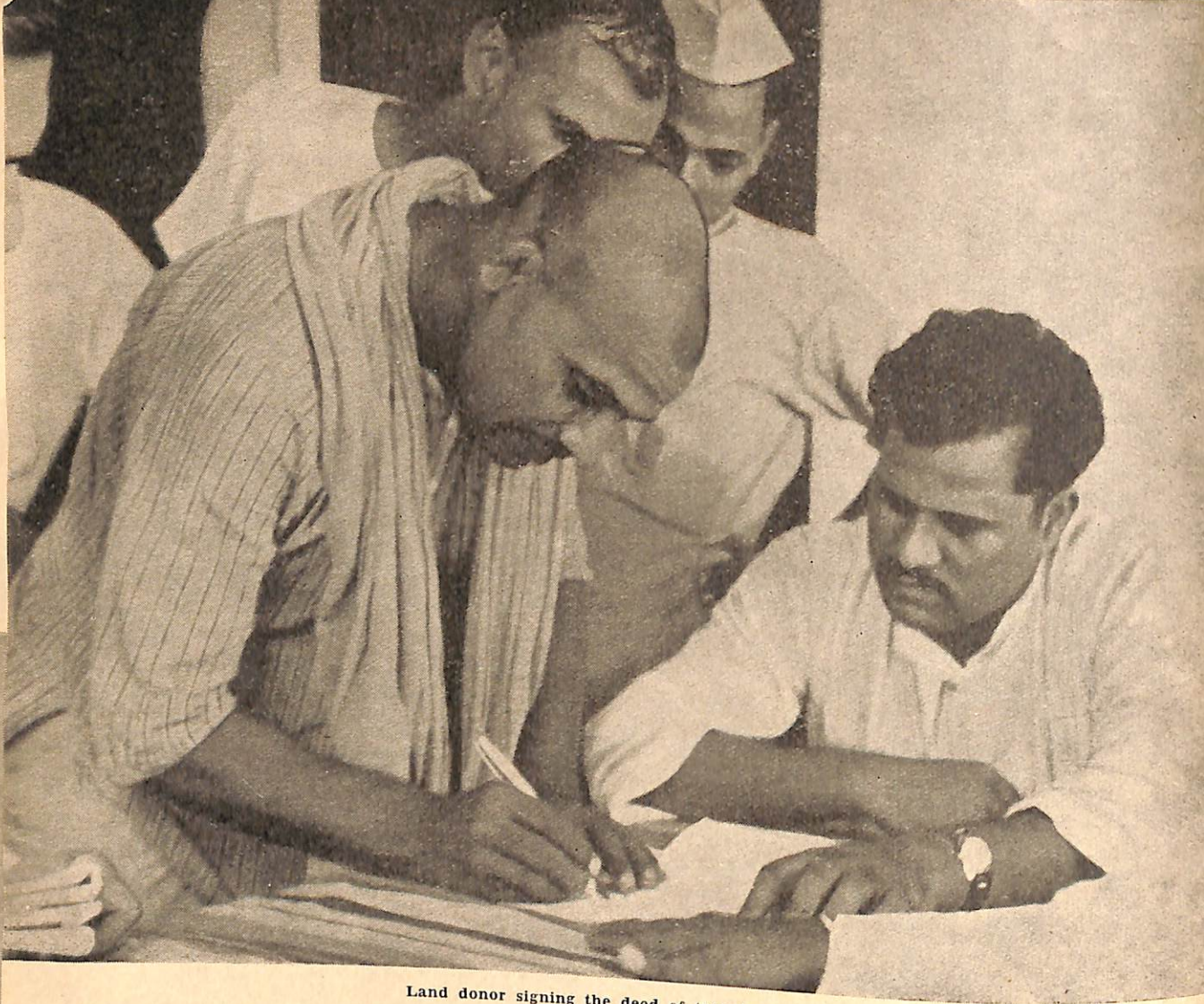




The morning prayer at Khadigram

"Only I can know", said Vinoba, "what I have got from the *Ashram*. It was an early hope of mine that I should kill at least one Englishman and crown my career. But Bapu cured me of that desire. It is he who has extinguished the volcano of anger and passion which was ever alive in me. I feel that I have been progressing every day of my life in the *Ashram*".

"You may stay days and days with him (Vinoba)", wrote Mahadev Desai, "without knowing him and, when you know him you only begin to know him. You meet with a reserve which you cannot easily break. He does not talk much, rarely does he say anything about himself and yet", continues Mahadev Desai, "if you could get at the bottom of his profound depths, you are sure to exclaim, 'no-where have I struck such treasures' ". But with all his reserve, with



Land donor signing the deed of transfer

his disciples, Vinoba is different. His boys know him better than anyone else. One of them has strung together some rare reminiscences which are of profound interest.

Vinoba's self-discipline is of a rare kind. He is generally out of his bed at the stroke of 3 in the morning. Once it so happened that even though he was awake at the stroke of 3 he could not leave his bed until 6 o'clock. Penitent, he fasted for three days. And since then there has not been a day, except when he is ill, when he has missed the morning hour of 3. Every morning at that hour, you

might, if you are fortunate enough to be out of your bed then, listen to the Sanskrit verses from the Upanishads and the Gita in his melodious voice.

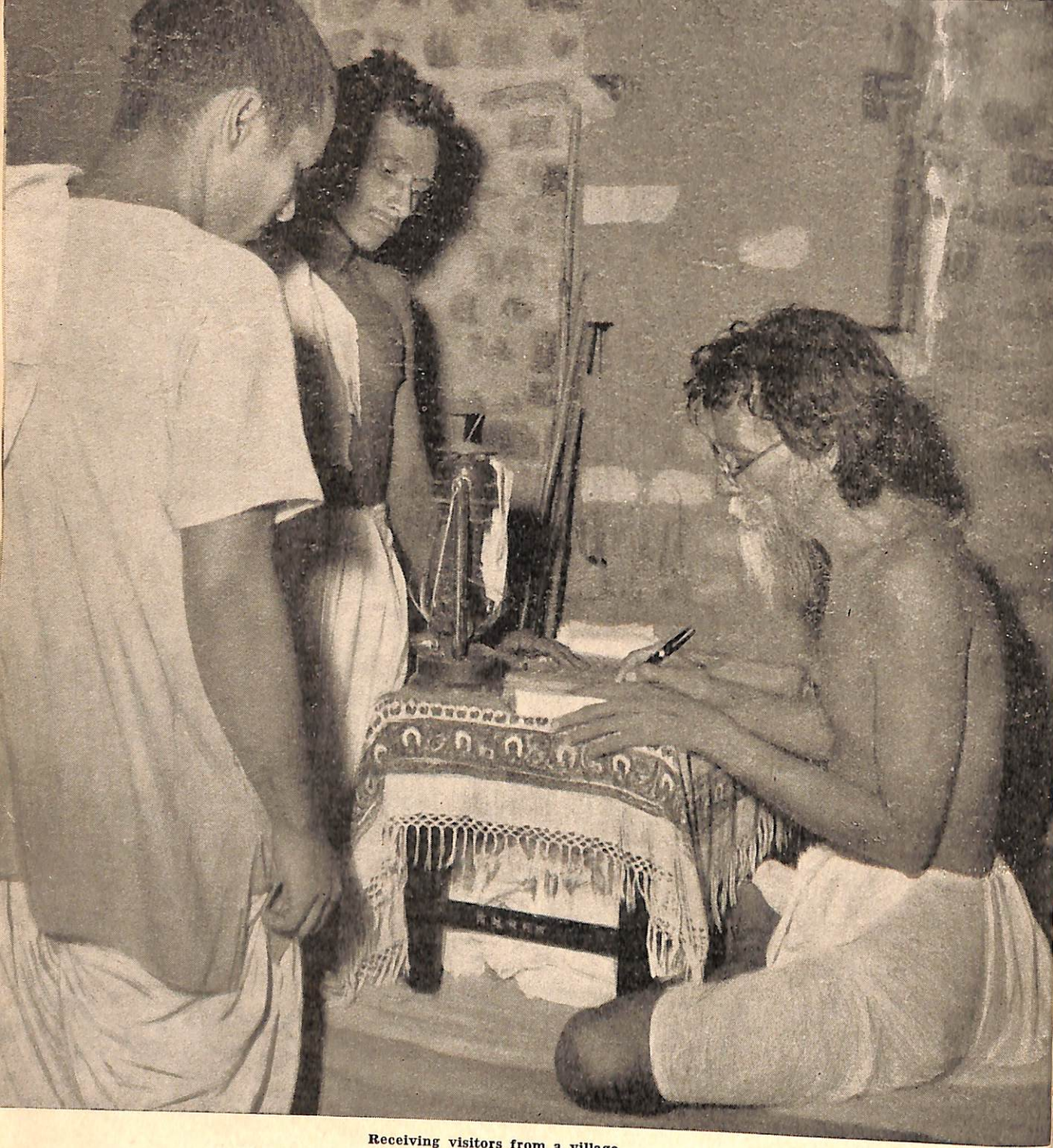
His disciples have found him a strict disciplinarian and a hard taskmaster. But he so commanded their affection that they wept unconsolably on the day he left the *Ashram*.

A friend who saw Vinoba during the early thirties describes him thus: "He lowered his glasses and I could see two steady flames. Vinoba is neither handsome nor ugly. Dark, light of build. Severe discipline and ascetic rigour have reduced the little muscle he might have had into less. His body is a reed; his teeth. . . . He is very retiring, reminded me of a coconut: 'will have to break the outer shell to reach the soothing liquid within.' Vinoba has an art of withholding himself, of burying himself within himself".

Vinoba has mastered most of the religious and philosophic lore of his land and he seems to live and move and have his being in it. In one of his articles in the *Maharashtra Dharma*, a Marathi monthly issued from Wardha, and containing articles written by Vinoba alone, he thus explained Ramdas, and indirectly his own philosophy of life:

"We sleep, we walk, we work, we live and we die. All these are passive processes. Do we have sleep or does the sleep devour us? We live because we cannot die. That is how we drag out our meaningless existence. There is no independence in any of our acts. None of our acts is, therefore, active. It is all passive. Is that life worth living? Shri Ramdas Swami wanted to teach independent action—all action in the active mood and not in the passive. He wanted to die before death; wanted liberty and, therefore, he left home and all and told the youth of the world to resort to life in the hermitage in the prime of their years. He practised the 'Bhagwat Dharma' in his childhood and youth like Prahlad and set an example to the whole of Maharashtra".

Vinoba believes in *swadhyaya*—study of the chosen subject. Though a very well-read man, he has been extremely selective in his studies. He says, "I have read a lot of Sanskrit. But I have not yet read *Shakuntala*. The speech of God is for freedom, *Moksha*; not for intellectual delight and luxury. I learnt Sanskrit not to read *Shakuntala* but to learn the Gita, the Vedas, the Upanishads and the Brahmasutras; for things that make for freedom of the soul,



Receiving visitors from a village

and not for poetry and literature. Philosophy and Mathematics are my subjects and not literature”.

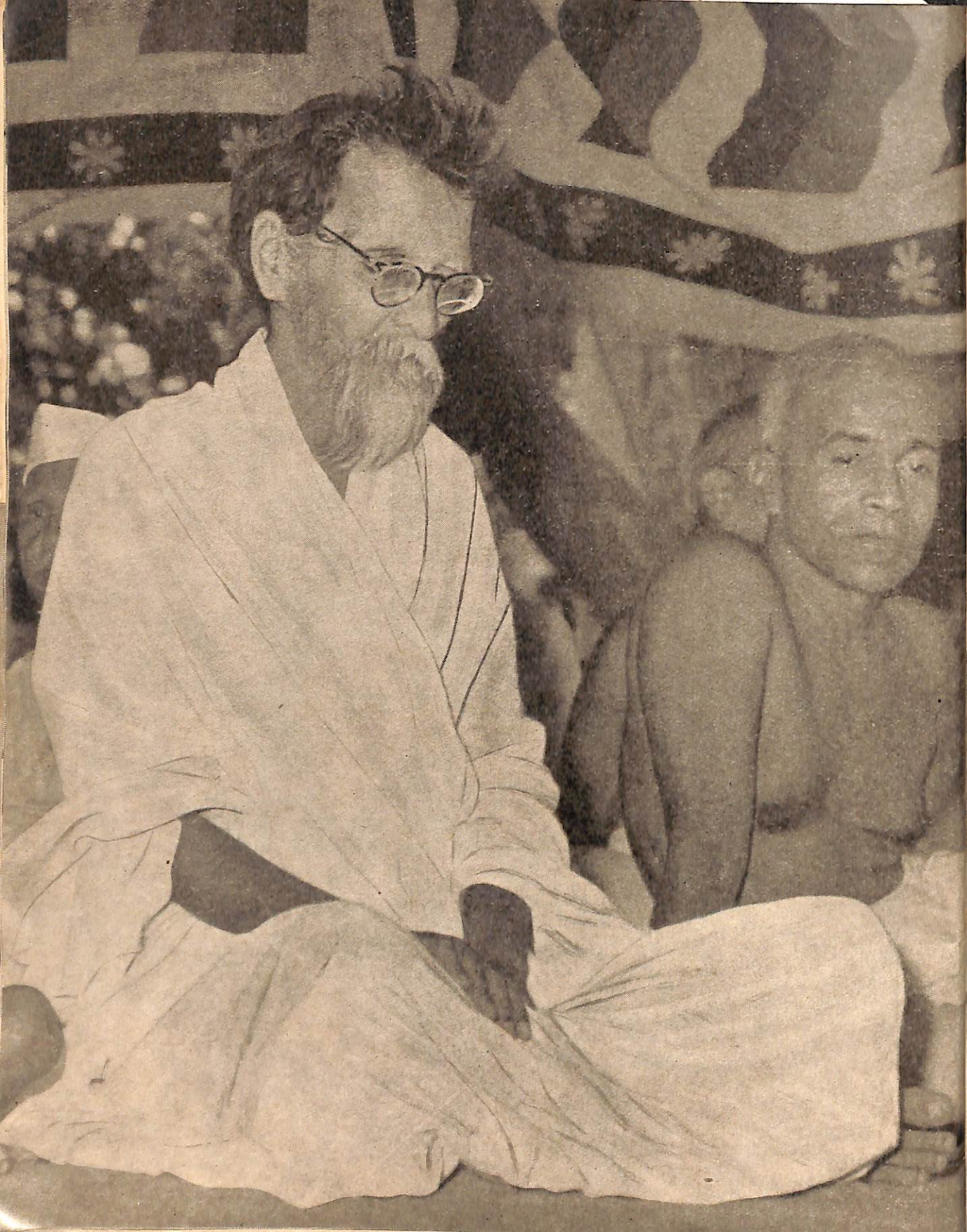
Vinoba is a great scholar. His knowledge of Sanskrit is profound; few have gone so deeply into the study of our Classics. The Vedas and the Puranas are to him like the mirror in the palm. Scholarship is not beyond the reach of many. Indeed quite a number have vast learning; but only a few can claim really outstanding erudition. But fewer are those who have assimilated learning and made it an instrument to aid them in life's pilgrimage. Vinoba's knowledge has ripened into wisdom. He searches out new paths. He does not seek to obstruct the known avenues of learning. To spend a few days with him is an education and an experience.

And he is made after the Gita and the Upanishads. He has read all the available commentaries on them. He went about on foot for months in the villages and mountains of the Deccan in search of *Pundits* and *Jnanis* in order to learn from them. He conducted Gita and Upanishad classes. He is no stranger to walking long distances. In his early days, covering 400 miles on foot, he delivered 50 discourses on the Gita. His *Maharashtra Dharma* contained his own commentaries on the Upanishads and other philosophic lore in the light of his experience.

“He has spurned literature”, wrote a close friend of Vinoba, “but I know very few Gujarati scholars like him”. A multi-linguist, Vinoba knows about 18 Indian and foreign languages which include Marathi, Gujarati, Hindi, Bengali, Oriya, Punjabi, Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam, Arabic, Persian, French and English. He learnt Arabic at the age of 46 with a view to studying the Quran in the original. Vinoba's language is simple and direct. He is very meticulous about the choice of words. There is no verbiage in him. In the use of words he exercises rare economy. Vinoba himself once said:

“Choose your words carefully. For if the words you choose are not appropriate, your expression instead of being substantial may be just airy. Some words carry inadequate sense, some more than the adequate, and some again have contrary connotations. One must avoid all these defects and express a thing exactly as it takes shape in the mind.”

Vinoba is an orator of distinction and a matchless writer too. The clarity of his thought and vision is remarkable. But he has always



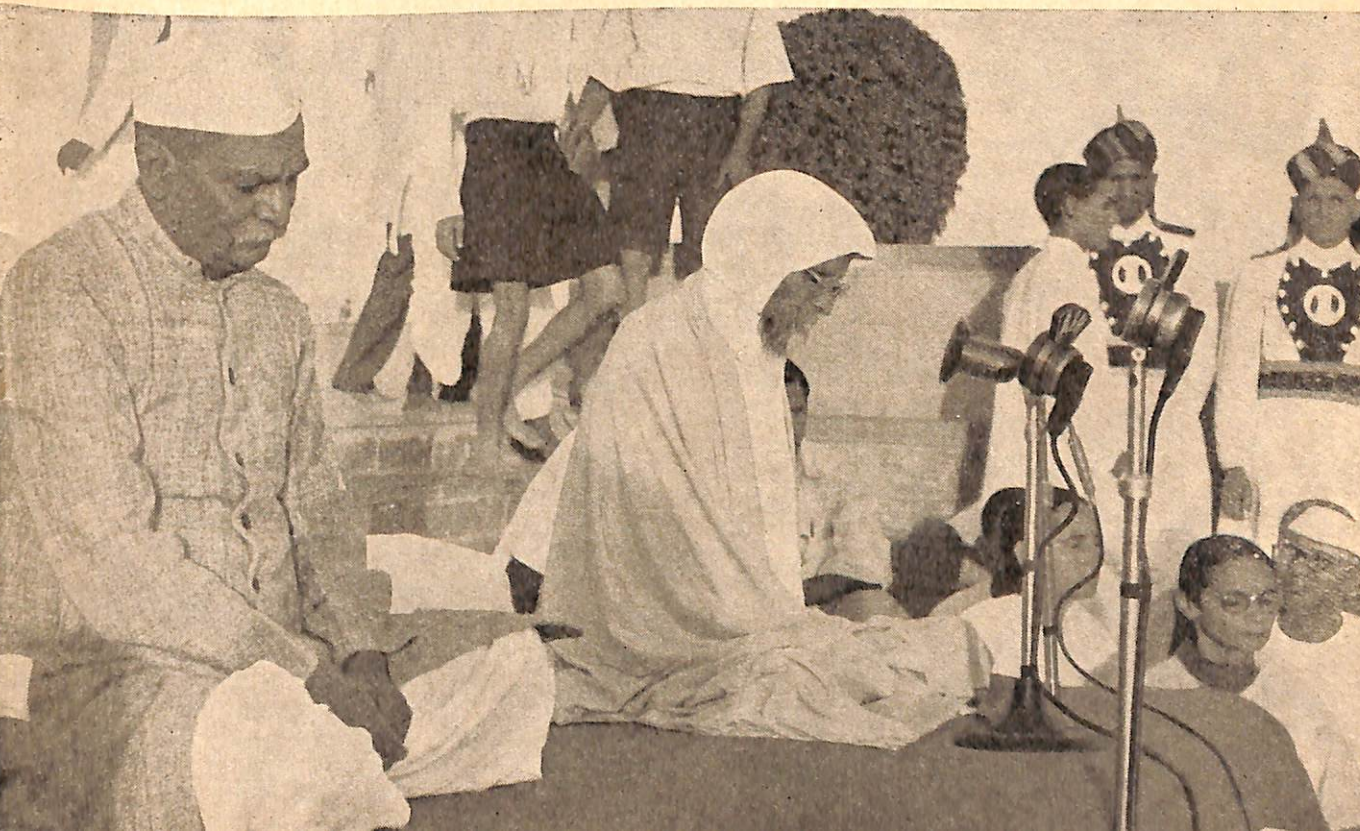
shunned publicity and kept away from the bustle of public life.

Vinoba is very original in his ideas and approach. His speeches reveal his profound scholarship, learning and his worldly wisdom. There is not a day when he does not address audiences. "And what he says is not political froth and he has always something new to add", says Jayaprakash Narayan. It is indeed a remarkable feat. And in dealing with questions of the most fundamental importance he brings erudition and wisdom together in the simplest language.

Of Vinoba's works, his *Gitai*, the Marathi rendering of the Gita, dedicated to the memory of his mother, enjoys great popularity. Of it, Mahadev Desai wrote: "He has produced a Marathi translation of the Gita in parallel verse which reproduces the haunting music of the original in an amazing degree. A hundred thousand copies of it have been sold in Maharashtra". His *Gita Pravachan* in Hindi, a translation from the original Marathi, has gone through five editions, the number of copies running into sixty-six thousand.

Until he launched the *Bhoodan Yajna* in 1951, Vinoba's name came into prominence only thrice, but it was only for the time being. He became the leader of the Nagpur National Flag Satyagraha in

A prayer meeting at Rajghat



1923, for one night—and that too accidentally. The other members of the Committee responsible for the movement were arrested suddenly. Vinoba alone remained to carry on. Next day, when instructions were issued to restart the movement, he was imprisoned with the others. Coming out three months later, he went back to his cottage at Wardha.

The following year, in 1924, Mahatma Gandhi chose him to lead the Guruvayur Satyagraha in Kerala, against the ban on the Harijans' entry to temples.

The smooth, studious tenor of his life at the *Ashram* was again shaken the third time in October 1940, when the Mahatma chose him and introduced him to the readers of the *Harijan*, as the first individual Satyagrahi. Only a few people knew Vinoba at that time; for a day he made news and again retired into obscurity.

Gandhiji had great affection for Vinoba and equally great esteem. Gandhiji consulted Vinoba on many important questions before taking a decision.

Dr. Radhakrishnan was to leave for Oxford during the early thirties. He went to *Sevagram* to see Gandhiji. He wanted to have his (Gandhiji's) blessings before embarking upon his professional duties. A friend who was present at the time records: "The scene still stays in my mind. The Great Soul on one side and the great Teacher on the other. One was the Doer saluted by the world, the other the Thinker who had conquered the world".

On that significant occasion when the philosopher was taking leave, Gandhiji told the great scholar, "Near at hand in Paunar lives Vinoba. You must meet him. It will be a pleasure".

Introducing Vinoba to the public, Gandhiji wrote in the *Harijan* of the 20th October, 1940:

"He (Vinoba) believes in the necessity of political independence for India. He is an accurate student of history. He believes that the real independence of the villager is impossible without a constructive programme in which *Khadi* is at the centre. He believes that the *Charkha* is the most suitable symbol of non-violence which has become an integral part of his life..... He has never enjoyed the limelight of the political platform. With many good workers he believes that silent work with civil disobedience in the background is far more effective than the already crowded political platform".



Women helpers at Vinoba Bhave's camp

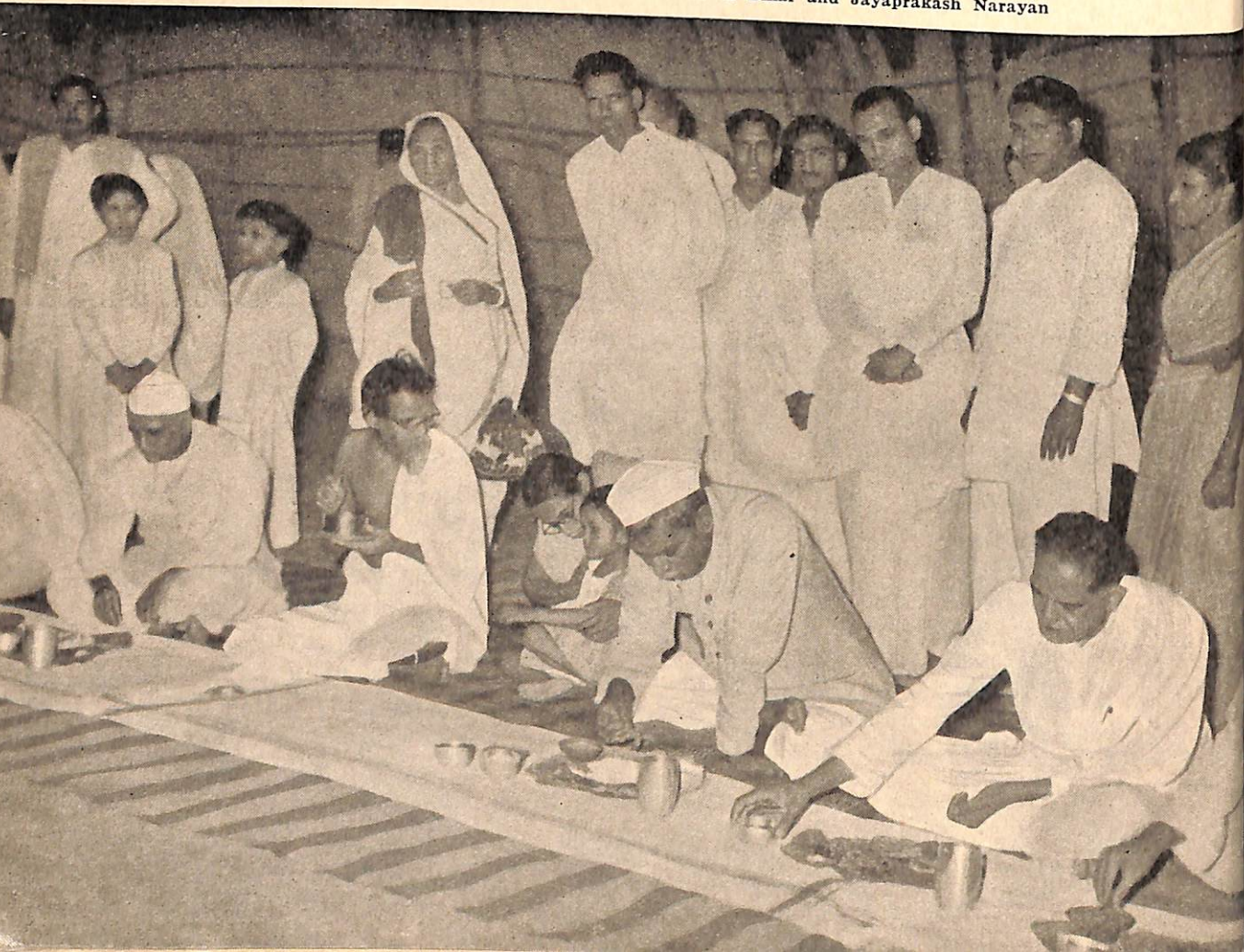
"He is a Sanskrit scholar. He joined the *Ashram* almost at its inception. He was among the first members. In order to better qualify himself he took one year's leave to prosecute further studies in Sanskrit and, practically at the same time at which he had left the *Ashram* a year before, he walked into it without notice. I had forgotten he was to arrive that day. He has taken part in every manual activity of the *Ashram* from scavenging to cooking. Though he has a marvellous memory, and is a student by nature, he has devoted the largest part of his time to spinning in which he has specialised as very few have".

"He has abolished every trace of untouchability from his heart.....He has an army of disciples and workers who would rise to any sacrifice at his bidding. He is responsible for producing a young man who has dedicated himself to the service of lepers.....His devotion to the cause of *Daridra Narayan* took him to a village near Wardha and now he has gone still further and lives in Paunar, 5 miles from Wardha".

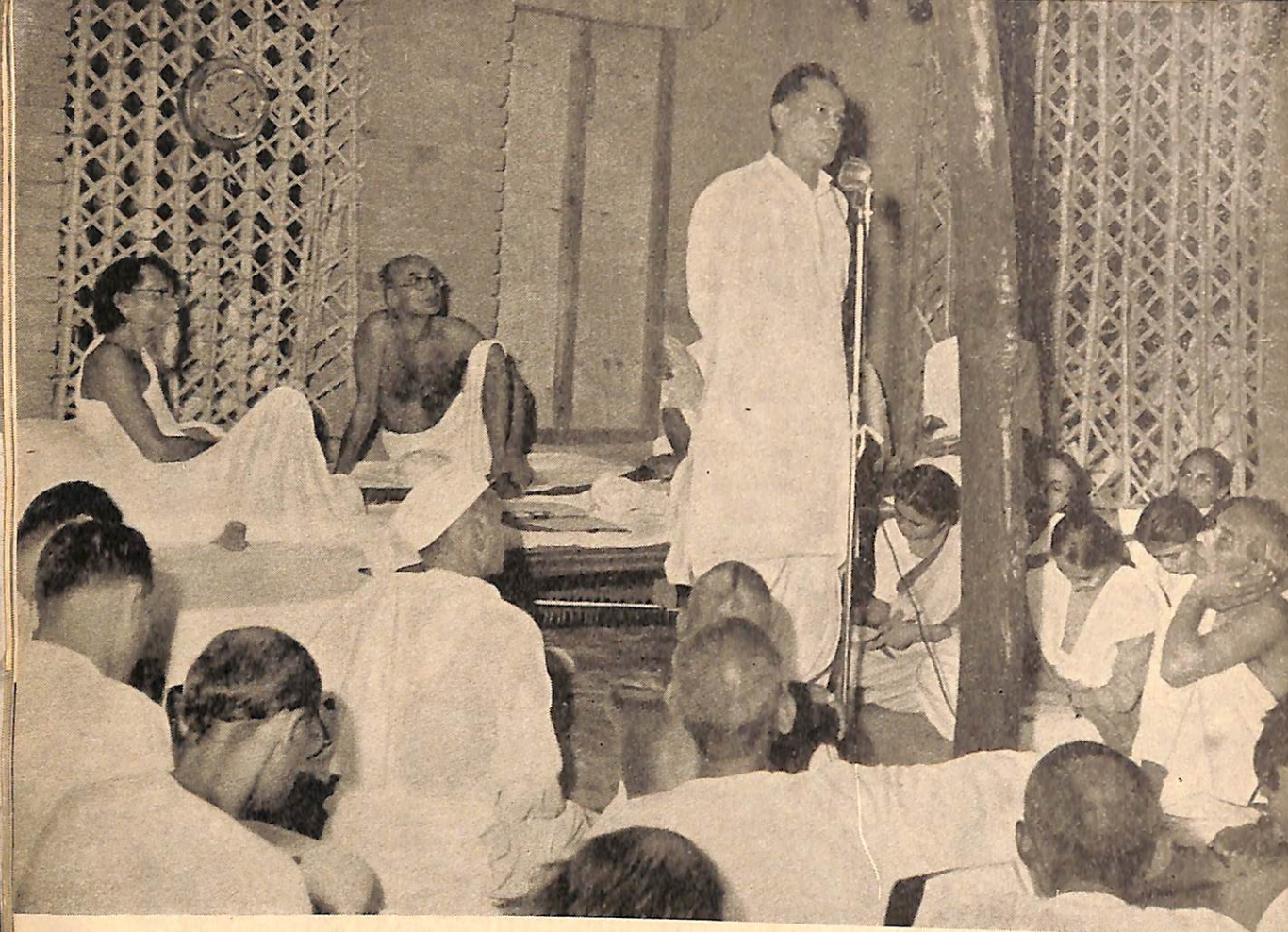
Vinoba was interned in the Nagpur prison for offering Satyagraha in 1923. Sri Rajagopalachari, who paid a visit to Vinoba, wrote:

"Look at Vinoba, gentle as an angel, whose soaring spirit has reached the heights of scholarship, philosophy and religion, and yet whose humility is so genuine and successful that no official who does not know him can discover his greatness. He

At dinner with the President, the Governor of Bihar and Jayaprakash Narayan







Jayaprakash Narayan at a public meeting in Khadigram

breaks stone metal according to the 'class' the jailor has put him in and no one knows the physical torture he silently bears. But we at the prison gates who hear about the treatment accorded to him give way to an involuntary shudder".

In recent years Vinoba has changed a great deal. He is no longer the shy, reserved person he was before he launched the *Bhoodan Yajna*. Now he likes to meet people, discuss with them and address public meetings. He believes that his thoughts and ideas should reach the largest number of people so that they may be able to grasp and follow his message of peace. According to Tukdoji Maharaj, the renowned *Bhajan* singer of Maharashtra, there was a time when Vinoba was not easily accessible. Tukdoji writes: "God is for the good of all. What was Bapu if he was not God? Today the revered

Vinoba has become God. Vinoba was not what he is today. His was a secluded life. He did not meet anyone nor did he talk to anyone. Had Bapu been with us today, we would not have found Vinoba going from village to village. He talks at you; never talks with you....."

Vinoba is a man of action. He never preaches anything which he does not practise. Addressing his disciples Vinoba once said: I would love to practise and preach my principles until my death. I could have done so by travelling in Maharashtra. I would have covered the whole of Maharashtra, but that way of preaching I have found to be futile. I could not preach the 'Nishkam Yoga' of the Gita by discussions, speeches and sermons. I do not think I can preach the living principles of the Upanishads in any way other than this, viz., that of surrounding myself, as I have done, by a few boys and instilling these principles into them. I may write five books or deliver five lectures. They will disappear sooner than a flash of lightning. But if you learn them and live them as I want you to do, I am sure you will leave a permanent impression on the world."

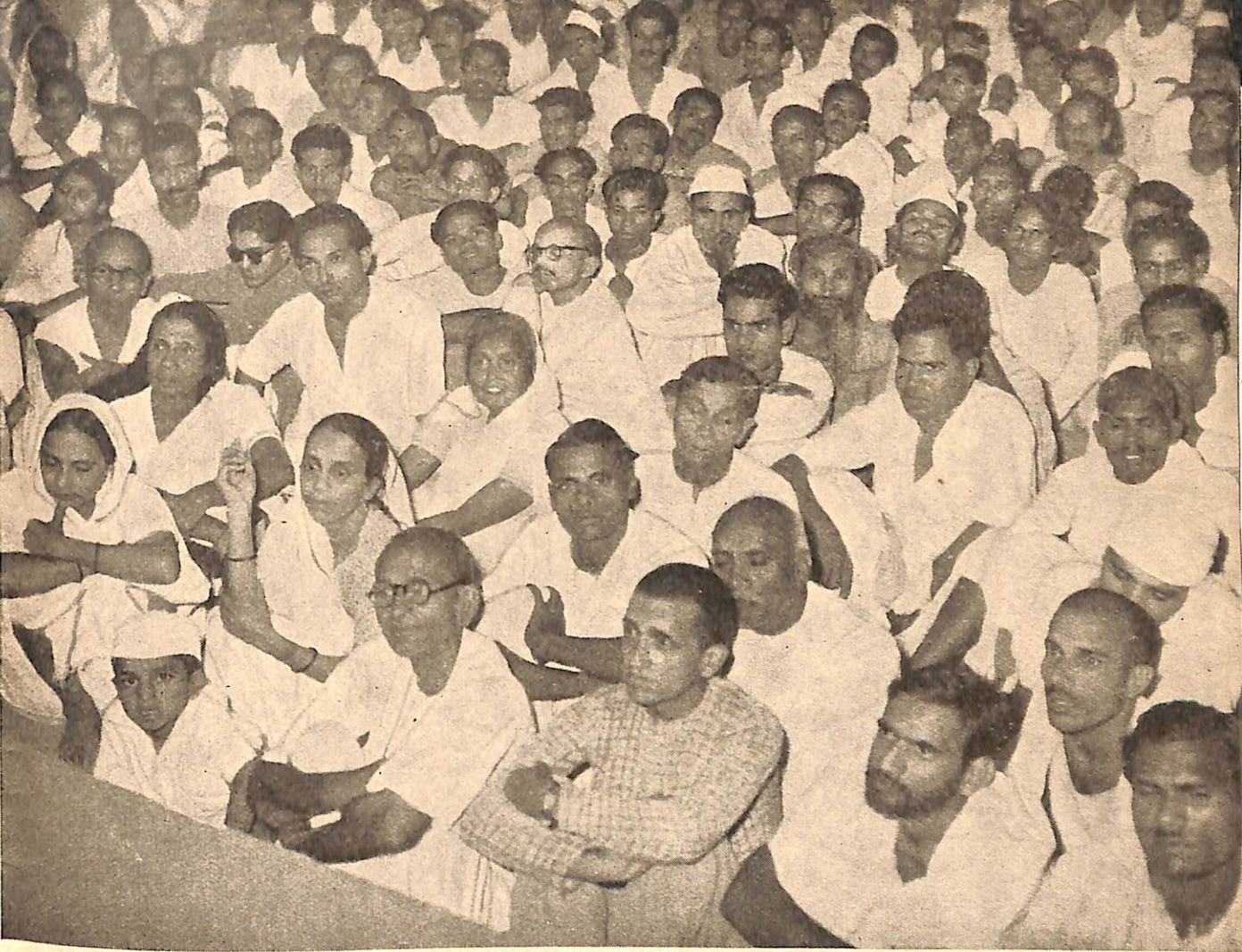
Despite the fact that he suffers from duodenal ulcer and is physically weak, Vinoba is never inactive. He takes very little food. His food consists mainly of honey and curd which he takes five times a day at regular intervals. Yet, somehow he finds the energy to walk 10 to 15 miles a day—in the summer months only 10 miles a day. When he is on the march, he and his disciples walk up in some sleepy village at 3 in the morning. There is a clapping of hands, a tinkling of bells, the flicker of a kerosene lantern, the shuffling of sandals in the dust and the small group departs for the next village, singing hymns. When he is not on the march he gets up an hour later and meditates for an hour. At five, he has his first cup of curd with honey, swishing each mouthful eight times before swallowing. Vinoba's entourage numbers a dozen or more energetic young men and women who stay with him three months to a year, so that the membership is constantly changing. Some of his disciples usually precede him to the next village to announce his arrival and to see that everything is in order.

With all his idealism, Vinoba is a stern realist and a practical man. When he wandered into the areas from which the police had

warned him to stay away, he remained unscathed. He preached the gospel of *Ahimsa* but soon found that the mere preaching of *Ahimsa* was not enough. "I confess", Vinoba said, "that the incendiary and murderous activities did not unnerve me, because I know that the birth of a new culture has always been accompanied in the past by blood baths. But what is needed is not merely not to get panicky but to keep our heads cool and find a peaceful means of resolving the conflict. The Police are not expected to think out and institute reforms. To clear a jungle of tigers, their employment would be useful. But here we have to deal with human beings, however mistaken and misguided. When a new idea is born, mere repression is of no avail."

"Thus has the new apostle lived and moved amidst us, arousing new hope and opening new vistas of a new life and a new civilisation", said Jayaprakash Narayan, the Socialist Leader, addressing a public meeting.

Such is the man who is working a silent revolution. India is the fortunate field of his activity but a time may come soon when the whole world may have to come round to Vinoba's way of thinking.



Delegates at the Sarvodaya Sammelan

CHAPTER IV

THE MESSAGE

The world of today seems to have become an experimenting ground for the destructive potentialities of science. Though science has made man's life fuller in many ways, its power for good seems to have been outweighed by its power for evil. "Science," says

Vinoba, "can transform this earth into heaven". But has it? Nor are there any sure indications that it is going to do so. "It (science) can do so only in combination with non-violence", says Vinoba.

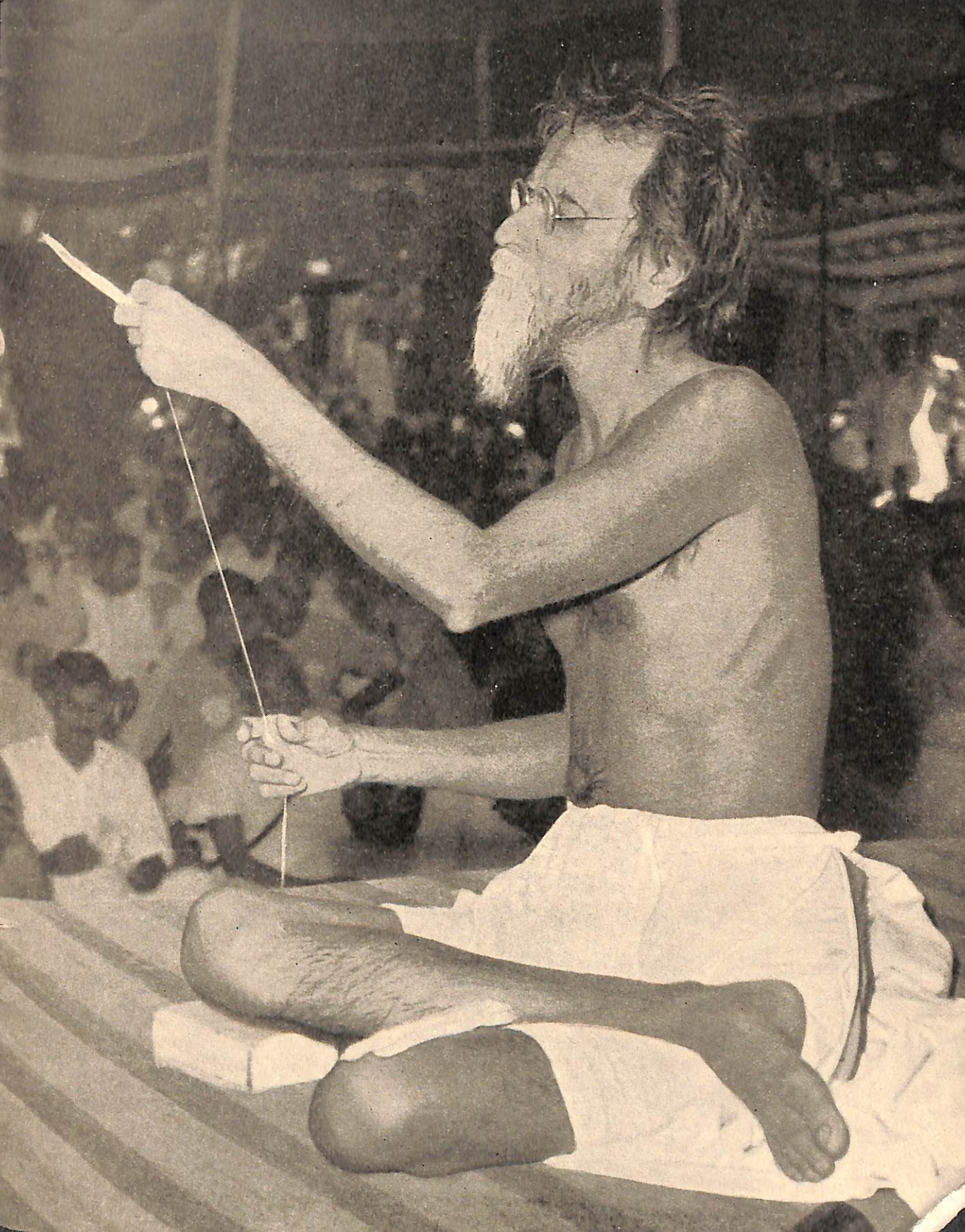
Addressing a public meeting, Acharya Vinoba declared, "Blessed are those who have received land, but thrice blessed are those who have had the privilege of giving away the land to the landless." It is not that the landless are being given land that makes Vinoba's movement great; it is the spirit in which the land is transferred that makes it revolutionary. "It is not charity but God's justice", says the donee; "it is not mine but God's land that I share with another," says the donor. *Dan* (gift) here becomes the quality that humbles the donor and the donee before God. "The grace of God has released hidden streams of compassion and love in the hearts of the people of this ancient land and with His grace alone will a new world be created", says Vinoba.

Secondly, Vinoba's movement shows us that political government is only a means to an end, the end being the welfare of the people. Vinoba thinks that there should be no concentration of the power to act and execute at any one centre. "Every village should be enabled to develop it. I, therefore, want that the village must have the power to decide what things it will import or what not. The concentration of this power has given us big nations—that is big political machineries. In a world made smaller by science, let small groups like the villages have the power to decide", says Vinoba.

But it is not the way of escapist renunciation that Vinoba preaches. "If India continues to be the poor and miserable country which it is today, there is no hope for India", he says. These are pregnant words. It is not the material riches, but the feeling of ownership and the inequities in practice that are potentially harmful. So Vinoba preaches the path of *aparigraha*—non-possession and a spirit of detached trusteeship.

Acharya Vinoba's mission does not stop with the distribution of land. It is, as he says, a moral and a spiritual movement which aims at *sarvodaya*—welfare of all—through the path of *aparigraha*, non-possession, and not through dispossession.

"Along with the *Bhoodan* work I have recently launched another programme—the *Sampattidan Yajna*. It is necessary for the fulfil-



ment of the *Bhoodan Yajna*", said Vinoba addressing the Chandil Sarvodaya Sammelan in 1952. Vinoba shares the view that "we cannot achieve the object of economic independence and economic equality unless we give effect to *Sampattidan*". Vinoba feels that from *Bhoodan* to *Sampattidan* is a natural step. Landless people who receive land under the *Bhoodan* scheme obviously cannot cultivate it unless they have the tools. Then why was not the *Sampattidan* launched at the same time as the *Bhoodan Yajna*, one may ask. "I knew it from the beginning", says Vinoba, "but I chose to follow the formula which says 'attend ye to the root and all else will grow automatically'. The land problem is more fundamental than any other".

In an appeal to the people exhorting them to give their co-operation in his mission, Vinoba says:

"I appeal to you all to contribute your share in the *Prajasooya Yajna* (a ritual sacrifice for the sovereignty of the people) and by making this mission successful, establish non-violence as the rule of society in the economic sphere."

And he confidently asserts, "I make a claim to the correctness of this work for three reasons. It is in tune with the cultural traditions of India. It contains in it the seeds of economic and social revolution. And, lastly, it can help in the establishment of peace in the world Circumstances have compelled me to come out and be audacious enough to be an initiator of this great *Yajna* (*Bhoodan*). But whether it is impertinence or humility I dedicate it to God and request all my sisters and brothers to co-operate with me."

PRINTED BY THE PRODUCTION OFFICER,
UNITED PRESS, OLD SECRETARIAT, DELHI



THE PUBLICATIONS DIVISION
Ministry of Information and Broadcasting
Government of India

PRINTED IN INDIA